

LATE ELIZABETHAN SABBATARIANISM:

THE HISTORY OF AN IDEA

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Note on Style

So as not to give the appearance of quaintness to quotations, spelling and punctuation have been modernised, although titles of books have been reproduced in their original spelling to better enable the reader to locate them in indexes. Italics in an original text which were intended to indicate only that words were being quoted from another source, are not reproduced here.

Acknowledgements and Dedication

In writing this thesis I have naturally benefited from the help of many people. I would like to thank Barbara McCrae of Ormond College for the considerable trouble to which she went to locate and get me a set of volumes promisingly titled The Literature of the Sabbath Question.

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Abbreviations:

- Andrewes, Lancelot Andrewes, The Moral Law Expovnded
London, 1642.
- Bownde. Nicholas Bownde, The Doctrine of the
Sabbath, London, 1595.
- Greenham. Richard Greenham, The Works of ...
M. Richard Greenham, London, 1599. (No. 524
in The English Experience, Amsterdam,
1973.).
- Perkins. William Perkins, The Work of William
Perkins, Ian Breward (ed.), Appleford,
Berkshire, 1970.

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION AND METHOD

In 1595 a 'godly' Suffolk clergyman, Nicholas Bownde, published a book called The Doctrine of the Sabbath.¹ He wanted people in England to observe the Lord's day or Christian Sabbath better than they had done hitherto. His book was at least partly based upon an as yet unpublished treatise by his step-father, 'godly' preacher Richard Greenham.² Greenham and Bownde, whom I shall call "the Sabbatarians",³ wanted people to spend Sundays "altogether in God's service".⁴

Calvin had urged people to do much the same thing forty years before.⁵ This use of the Christian Sabbath was outlined in the marginalia of both the Geneva and Bishops' Bibles.⁶ Throughout Elizabeth's reign the population had

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1. Nicholas Bownde, The Doctrine of the Sabbath, London, 1595. (Hereinafter "Bownde").
 2. Richard Greenham, A Treatise of the Sabbath, in Richard Greenham, The Works of ... M. Richard Greenham, London, 1599. (No. 524 in The English Experience, Amsterdam, 1973.), and see Bownde, sig. A3 v.
 3. The abusive term "Sabbatarian" seems to first appear in the literature in 1607. Thomas Rogers, The Catholic Doctrine of the Church of England ..., 1607, (Parker Society, Cambridge, 1854.), pp 18-19.
 4. Nicholas Bownde, Sabbathvm Veteris et Novi Testamenti, London, 1606, sig. A[1] v.
 5. Sermons of M. Iohn Calvin vpon the X. Commandementes ..., Translated, T.H., London, 1579, sig. fol 30 v - sig. fol 46 r.

NB: The injunction to spend the entire day in some form of worship is implicit, though not stressed.

Although Calvin articulated this idea I do not suggest that he necessarily developed it.

ibid., sig. fol 36 v.

6. Richard L Greaves, "The Origins of English Sabbatarian Thought", Sixteenth Century Journal, 12 (1981), p 19, at p 21. Note, the marginalia of both required the complete giving over of Sunday to God's worship.

been exhorted to better Sabbath observance by homilies,⁷ catechisms⁸ and various published sermons and tracts.⁸

What was relatively new about the two treatises was, firstly, their theological argumentation. They followed an argument first presented by Greenham's good friend Lancelot Andrewes in his catechistical lectures at Cambridge during the 1570s and '80s.¹⁰ They claimed, contrary to centuries of theological tradition, that the whole of the Fourth Commandment bound man on earth for all time. Accordingly they asserted that this "immortal commandment of Almighty God"¹¹ removed any authority the church or state might have had to abolish the Sabbath, alter its frequency, or alter the day of the week on which it was celebrated. Until then it had been accepted that, while part of the Fourth Commandment bound Christians, part had been abrogated by the gospel, although there had not always been agreement on precisely what had been abrogated, and what had endured.

Secondly, the Sabbatarians had an entirely new conviction of the relative importance of Sabbath observance. As Greenham put it, "this one precept is the

7. ibid., pp 23-23.

8. ibid., p 22.

9. ibid., pp 22-27.

10. Lancelot Andrewes, The Morall Law Expovnded..., London, 1642, (hereinafter "Andrewes").

11. Bownde, Sabbathvm, sig. ¶2v.

school of all other Commandments". Because of this conviction the Sabbatarians expended a disproportionate amount of energy expounding the theology and uses of the Sabbath.¹²

In some ways the Sabbatarians' theological argument was extraordinarily bold. Christ himself said that the Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath.¹³ Calvin had already described the sort of ideas Greenham and Bownde now proposed as a "gross and carnal superstition".¹⁴ And yet Sabbatarianism swept the country with "incredible" speed. It became particularly important to the 'godly' sort as a shibboleth of true religion.¹⁵

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12. Greenham, Works, (hereinafter "Greenham"), p 307. Greenham "travailed above most of his time" at his treatise, and died unsatisfied with his efforts. Bownde published two Sabbatarian treatises, one a re-working of the other, the 800 pages of which account for well over half his published literary output.
Bownde, sig. A3 v.
Greenham, sig. A6 v.
13. Mark, 2:27.
14. Robert Cox, The Literature of the Sabbath Question, 2 Vols., Edinburgh, 1865, Vol. I, p 129.
NB: Calvin appears to be commenting on the opinion that seventh day Sabbaths remained a divinely ordained institution after the coming of Christ, which accordingly impugned the authority of the church to ordain a Sabbath replacing Sunday.
15. Thomas Fuller, The Church History of Britain, London, 1655, p 227.
cf. Peter Heylyn, The History of the Sabbath, London, 1636, pp 251-2.
And see p 73 note 27.

If by becoming more familiar with the circumstances and ideas of men like Bownde in the 1590s we can see that his book was not extraordinary, but rather a natural product of those circumstances and ideas, we may claim to have come to some historical understanding of why it was written. That is the aim of this essay.

A number of histories of Sabbatarianism are what I shall loosely call 'influence studies'.¹ While many of them make efforts to demonstrate some of the social functions of Sabbatarianism, in tracing attitudes to the Sabbath over time, they give us helpful ancestries of Sabbatarian ideas but are inadequate as explanations of the full attractiveness of Sabbatarianism. Such studies often focus on formal propositions rather than on the ways in which those propositions moved men.² They present the historical

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1. Patrick Collinson, "The Beginnings of English Sabbatarianism" in C W Dugmore and Charles Duggan (eds), Studies in Church History, 1 (1964), p 207;

M M Knappen, "The Early Puritanism of Lancelot Andrewes", Church History, 2 (1933), p 95;

Richard L Greaves, "The Origins of English Sabbatarian Thought" in Sixteenth Century Journal, 7 (1981), p 19;

Other more general surveys which nevertheless spend considerable time tracing influences over a given period include:

Winton E Solberg, Redeem the Time: The Puritan Sabbath in Early America, Cambridge, (Mass.), 1977, Chapters 1, 2, and 3.

W B Whitaker, Sunday in Tudor and Stuart Times, London, 1933.

M M Knappen, Tudor Puritanism, Chicago, 1939, (Gloucester, Mass, 1963), Book II, Chapter 24.

cf. Patrick Collinson, "'A Magazine of Religious Patterns': An Erasmian Topic Transposed in English Protestantism", Renaissance and Renewal in Christian History, Studies in Church History, 14, Oxford, 1977, p 223, at p 225.

2. cf. J Dunn, "The Identity of the History of Ideas", Philosophy, 43 (1968), p 85, at p 85.

phenomenon of Sabbatarianism as a series of propositions. The ways in which particular Sabbatarians differed on certain points - however minutely - are explored, often leaving their common concerns either neglected or obscured.³

In contrast Christopher Hill explores the possible attractiveness of Sabbatarianism as a social program.⁴ However his essay is unhelpful for us for two reasons. Firstly his focus is primarily upon the spread of Sabbatarian ideas through society rather than on their original development.

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3. Although, as we shall see, the Sabbatarians' basic motivations were very similar, Greaves and Solberg devote considerable energy to exploring the relatively small differences between Greenham's, Bownde's and Andrewes' positions on what was permissible Sabbath labour. This preoccupation with formal propositions leads Greaves to detect a "cleavage of opinion within the Puritan tradition itself" which seems to me to rely on flimsy evidence, and a premature "Anglican - Puritan controversy".

Greaves op cit, pp 24, 28.
cf. below, p 102, note 8.

4. Christopher Hill, "The Uses of Sabbatarianism", Chapter Five, Society and Puritanism in Pre-Revolutionary England, London, 1964.

Secondly, he, like others, seems repelled by the subject. Both he and J. W. Allen regard Sabbatarianism as "gloomy"⁵ and "oppressive"⁶ despite the Sabbatarians' protestations that their Sabbath was - for them - a delight. In addition Hill and Allen seem bemused by the theological argumentation of Sabbatarianism. Hill refers to the argument, or at least much of it, as "mere irrational Bibliolatry"⁷ and the Sabbatarians are under suspicion of finding Biblical justification for "doing what they would have done even if no texts could be found".⁸ Such an approach prevents Hill from exploring the ways in which ideas often expressed in theological terms might have exercised a more powerful effect on contemporary minds than they do upon us today.

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5. Christopher Hill, "Seventeenth Century English Society and Sabbatarianism", in J S Bromley and E H Kossmann (eds), Britain and the Netherlands II, Groningen, 1964, p 84, at p 91.
 6. J W Allen, English Political Thought 1603-1660, 2 Vols., London, 1938, Vol. I, pp 270, 272. Allen calls A Devine Tragedy Lately Acted, (1936), which lists God's judgements against Sabbath breakers, "a ludicrously horrible book". Later he suggests that "The book reads almost as if it had been intended for a burlesque".
ibid p 274.
 7. Hill, Society, p 146.
 8. ibid. p 167.

As I grew to understand the language of puritan spirituality better, it impressed itself upon me more and more as a compelling expression of human experience; and one which, like any other system of belief, could move men to do things which might seem inexplicable to those without an understanding of those ideas.⁹ I appreciated George Yule's call for a more adequate examination of the effect of the puritans' theological outlook on their history.¹⁰

My principal purpose, has not been to 'explain' Sabbatarian issues by illustrating a change in thought over time, but rather to explore sympathetically a coherent body of thought at a particular time. That time is the early and mid 1590s' although evidence from outside that period is used where it improves our understanding of those years. Instead of abstracting leading ideas or influences,

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9. Note in this context Keith Thomas' apparent desire to render certain religious controversies "more intelligible" by way of anthropological insights. Keith Thomas, "History and Anthropology", Past and Present, 24 (1963), p 3, at p 8.
 10. G Yule, "Theological Developments in Elizabethan Puritanism", Journal of Religious History, 1, (1960), p 16, at p 16.

I have tried to articulate what Skinner calls "the complex ... matrix within which the idea or event ... can be most meaningfully located".¹¹ I hope that that is valuable in itself.

The twist is that a description which helps us sympathetically understand what people were thinking will often stand as the best explanation of their thought that we can manage. In dissecting the Sabbatarian mind, if I have done my job properly, I have not described some end point of reasoning existing as a set of formal propositions. A good description of a body of thought should reveal its inner dynamics, and we shall most successfully be able to extract meaning when we see Sabbatarian thinking in the light of the problems

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11. Q Skinner, "The Limits of Historical Explanations", Philosophy, 41 (1966), p 199, at p 213.

Throughout I have used the word 'explanation' cautiously because it conjures up allusions to scientific explanation. If I were to present a list or "hierarchy of causes" to 'explain' the emergence of Sabbatarianism I would not know where to put "delight" and "assurance" in that hierarchy though they are most important when "describing the context itself" from which meaning can be extracted.

E H Carr, What is History?, 1961, Penguin, 1977, p 89. Skinner, op cit., p 214.

it was intended to solve.¹² Such a description dictates its own explanatory schema of why the Sabbatarians thought what they did, of what directions their thought was taking, how it was changing and why.¹³

12. As Dunn observes:

[T]hinking ... is not an activity which takes its meaning from a set of finished performances which have been set up in type and preserved in libraries, but an activity ... which is directed towards problem solving and not towards the construction of closed formal games.

Dunn, op cit., p 88, and
cf. R G Collingwood, "Question and Answer", Chapter V of Autobiography, 1944, Pelican Books.

13. cf. Dilthey. "Dissecting the products of the human mind ... is designed to give us insight into the origin, forms and function of the mental structure". W Dilthey, Selected Writings, edited and translated by H P Rickman, Cambridge, 1976, p 93, and cf. p 91.

III

My principal thesis is that Sabbatarianism emerged as a response to problems defined by the outlook of late Elizabethan 'godly' Protestants. The 'godly' were concerned to promote religious zeal. They were particularly concerned to eliminate popish 'abuses' in the church and often had presbyterian convictions or sympathies. I have sometimes referred to them as 'puritans',¹ and to the 'godly' divines of the late Elizabethan Church as the 'brethren'.²

I have sought to depict the milieu from which Sabbatarianism emerged by constructing a picture of the 'common mind' of late Elizabethan godly Protestantism, using the works of Sabbatarian divines³ and a number of their godly colleagues. It should become clear as the essay

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1. The godly themselves would have repudiated the label. Richard Greenham, The Works of ... Richard Greenham, London, 1612, [hereinafter cited as "Greenham, (1612),"] p 118.

NB: A reference to particular concerns of puritans should not be interpreted as a suggestion that such concerns necessarily distinguished the puritans from others. Often the puritans voiced concerns shared by large sections of the society.

2. A term which they used and Hooker identified as a "high term... of separation between such and the rest of the world". Richard Hooker, Of the Laws of Ecclesiastical Polity, London, 1593, (Folger Library Edition, Harvard, 1977.), [3:11], at p 18.
3. The focus is on the first generation of Sabbatarians - Greenham and Bownde - though I have used the writings of some early Jacobean Sabbatarians to help illuminate some themes.

progresses that those aspects of the 'godly' mind which I shall outline, were common to the Sabbatarians. Sometimes this can be shown by providing quotations from Sabbatarians which illustrate the points I am making and echo quotations from others. Where that has not been possible, sufficient common ground between Sabbatarian concerns and those more general concerns of the 'godly' should emerge by the end of the essay.⁴

Richard Rogers, and William Perkins, the two "non-Sabbatarians" most heavily relied upon, were basically sympathetic to the Sabbatarian position.⁵ Both would

4. I have used some material from a 1612 edition of Greenham's works which does not exist in earlier editions of his works. Other historians - for instance Hill - have used this material without qualm although its authenticity is not proven. It is possible that such material is apocryphal though there seems no reason to doubt Henry Holland's assertion that it was taken down by others who knew Greenham and heard him speak. Likewise Andrewes did not set down his lectures on the Ten Commandments. We have to make do with expansions of auditors' notes published decades after the lectures were given. In any case these sources have been used only to illustrate aspects of the 'common mind' not to isolate particular views on points of theological contention. Greenham, (1612), sig. A4 v.

5. William Perkins, The Works of the Famous and Worthey ... William Perkins, 3 Vols., London, 1616-1618 (hereinafter cited as "Perkins, Works"), I, pp 46-48; II, pp 106, 109-111, 286; III, p 240. Richard Rogers, Seven Treatises..., London, 1603, pp 166-67.

Note, both Andrewes and Perkins have been included within the Sabbatarian fold by some historians because their positions on principal Sabbatarian theological arguments were very close to those of Greenham and Bownde. I have not included them as Sabbatarians here because they did not exhibit the fervour for the Sabbath as a solution to the problems of the day which Greenham and Bownde did.

Solberg, op cit., p 57.

Greaves, op cit., p 26.

Knappen, "Early Puritanism", p 98 ff.

almost certainly have known Greenham.⁶ They shared his commitment to articulating a commonly held view of the godly life. Perkins has been chosen because, in my view, he more than anyone else articulated and responded to the emerging problems of Protestant spirituality. Rogers is of great interest because of his diary. The people we are studying insisted that the foundation of all religious knowledge and conviction was personal religious experience.⁷ Accordingly, by using Rogers' diary I have sought where possible to illustrate how the theology of the brethren is hewn from the rock of their daily experience.

The argument will be presented in three chapters. Chapter 2 will deal principally with what the brethren identified as social evil and why Sabbatarianism could have

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6. Rogers records a visit to Greenham's parish of Dry Drayton, in his diary. Greenham lived only four miles from Cambridge which he visited sometimes in order to preach. He was at Dry Drayton for approximately twenty years from 1570. Perkins was at Cambridge from 1577.

Richard Rogers and Samuel Ward, Two Elizabethan Puritan Diaries, M M Knappen (ed.), Chicago, 1933, (hereinafter "Rogers, Diary"), p 59.

W Haller, The Rise of Puritanism, New York, 1938, p 26.
William Perkins, The Work of William Perkins, Ian Breward (ed.), Appleford, Berkshire, 1970, (hereinafter cited as "Perkins"), p 3.

7. Perkins, p 308.

seemed to be an attractive remedy. Chapter 3 explores the ways in which Sabbatarianism could have been attractive to the godly individual seeking to live the godly life. In Chapter 4, having examined the attractions of Sabbatarianism, we shall be in a position to appreciate the theological arguments upon which it rested.

CHAPTER 2

SOCIAL EVIL AND RESPONSE

Sabbatarianism for the Reprobate

I

The Bible is a big book.

In the next two sections, in addition to introducing the reader to certain themes which will recur, I wish to outline some of the factors in the life and thought of the brethren which led them to focus on particular parts of the Bible. We shall see that the Decalogue figured prominently in their pastoral work and so in their theology. And some of the theological issues which sent them to the Decalogue raised interesting questions about the Fourth Commandment itself.

As Elizabeth's reign progressed men became acutely aware of the vigour of the enemies of true Protestantism. The godly saw themselves besieged on all sides by corrupted forms of religious doctrine and practice which, because they were wrought of the flesh, played on people's weaknesses and so attracted them away from the more exacting demands of true religion.

On the one hand was popery which preyed upon the weakness of the "ignoranter sort" for superstition,¹ and

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1. As Gifford, a godly minister with strong presbyterian sympathies, put it, "the ignoranter sort ... are so easily led astray by superstition or ... popery".

Dewey D Wallace Jr. "George Gifford, Puritan Propaganda and Popular Religion in Elizabethan England", Sixteenth Century Journal, 9 (1978), p 27, at p 39.

which many believed to be on the increase.² On the other³ hand the brethren saw burgeoning sectarianism, with many sects preaching libertine notions⁴ appealing to the lusts of the flesh.⁵ Such "enemies to God" also posed the threat of sedition, for they were also, necessarily, "enemies to his anointed": the prince.⁶

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2. The Catholic mission in England was pursuing its objectives with some success. In 1602 Josias Nicols - a presbyterian apologist - observed a "great increase of Papists". Similarly Rogers noted how Catholic devotional works, because of their superficial piety, had "snared many simple peoples consciences".

Josias Nicols, The Plea of the Innocent, 1602, p 172.
Rogers, Treatises, sig A6 v.
cf. Wallace op cit., p 39.

3. This image of siege from all sides is frequently used.

John Sprint, Propositions, Tending to Proove the Necessarie vse of the Sabbath..., London, [1607], pp 9, 10, ss 30-31.

Perkins Works, I, p 384.
Greenham, p 300.

And note Perkins' image of the church as Christ in the wilderness. Works, III, p 378.

4. I remind the reader that throughout the essay I am seeking to present the views of the godly brethren and am not, unless a contrary intention is expressed, seeking to deliberate on the accuracy of those views.
5. As early Jacobean Sabbatarian Sprint put it succinctly, "it is not hard to persuade unto that Liberty, which all men plead for and pursue". Sprint, op. cit., p 37.
6. Bownde, p 280. Obviously recusants were particularly suspect in the light of the discoveries of conspiracies against Elizabeth.

As well, there were alarming signs that what consensus there was amongst educated English Protestants was beginning to break down. Greenham spoke with alarm about the "new doctrine, heresies and sects, beginning now amongst us". But a greater fear was that such "opinions" having found fertile soil in "the simpler sort" were "like to invade the best learned".⁷

As early as 1579 Peter Baro had threatened the doctrinal consensus on predestination at Cambridge. The controversy intensified in the '90s.⁸ As well, by the 1580s Greenham's own former resident pupil,⁹ Robert Browne, was championing separatism.

In addition to luring men away from the narrow path of true religion the "manifold dissensions" would confuse people,¹⁰ sometimes leading them to forego any religion

7. Greenham, p 29.

8. H C Porter, Reformation and Reaction in Tudor Cambridge, Cambridge, 1958, Part III, passim.

Patrick Collinson, The Elizabethan Puritan Movement, University of California, 1967, pp 236-7.

M M Knappen, Tudor Puritanism, p 369.

9. William Haller, op cit., pp 28-9.

10. Perkins, p 323.

at all in exasperation.¹¹ And the uncertainties engendered by doctrinal plurality struck at the heart of the believer's assurance in God.¹² The "wandring soul" would continue to "see ... itself lost".¹³

There were two more pervasive enemies of godly Protestantism. Firstly there was massive public indifference which manifested itself either in absence from public religious exercises, or, in a popular "lip faith"¹⁴ devoid of all genuine religious feeling. Secondly, others, despite basically good intentions, were often "lukewarm" in religion.¹⁵ Such lukewarmness was founded upon what

11. Perkins, Works, III, p 324.

12. For the godly this was fundamental to true piety. See Chapter 3 Section IV.

13. Rogers, Treaties, sig. B[1] r.

14. Perkins, p 286.

15. Perkins, Works, I 550.
cf. Perkins in ibid., II, p 341 on "drowsy Protestants".

George Gifford called the "common mans pelagianism".¹⁶
Despite a lack of religious zeal men were confident that
God would recognise their generally good deeds and
intentions and forgive their sins.¹⁷

Accordingly the Devil's two weapons against true
conversion were, firstly the "presumption"¹⁸ of the 'common
man's pelagianism' which prevented the sinner from seeing
his complete unrighteousness before God and properly
fearing His justice. Secondly there was the "desperation"¹⁹
of salvation which prevented the sinner from fully
apprehending God's mercies so that he might "lay hold on
[His] promise of eternal life".²⁰

16. Wallace, op cit., p 36.

17. Gifford, in ibid. cf. Perkins, p 84.
and Nicholas Bownde, The Vnbeliefe of St
Thomas the Apostle, London, 1628, p 78.

18. Greenham, p 250.

19. ibid.

20. Rogers, Treatises, sig B[1] r.

Thus Greenham's elegant analysis of those who, falling prey to the errors of popular religion, believe that:

God ... is not so fearful and
merciful as his threatenings and 21
promises commend him to be.

In the following section we pass on to consider the brethren's response to this perception of the enemies of true religion.

21. Greenham, p 6. This was the diagnosis of the failings of popular religion in much of the godly's output. A strikingly similar diagnosis is offered by Rogers describing a "woeful creature" he visited "more hardened against God than I have seen any. No relenting for sin yet despairing in God's mercy".

And see Perkins on his own days as a reprobate believing neither in God nor the Devil, Heaven nor Hell.

Rogers, Diary, p 63.

Perkins, p 367.

The self imposed task "of taking religion to a recalcitrant folk"¹ in the midst of so many and vigorous adversaries² exercised a powerful influence on the theology of the brethren.

Against the 'common man's pelagianism' the godly emphasised the necessity for the personal experience of repentance and regeneration which was only made possible by the law. In a world pervaded by false doctrines to which men could cling to justify their sinfulness, God's law - a rule of perfection which could not be achieved by fallen men - stood to condemn them and pronounce their damnation.³

1. Wallace, op.cit., p 28.

2. Note: Perkins argued that the enemies of true religion "atheists, epicures, libertines, worldlings, neuters" were getting stronger. Perkins, p 22.

3. ibid., p 289.

Note Perkins had a notorious penchant for preaching the terrors of the law. His published sermon on Zephaniah 2:1,2, is a good example of his power, ibid., p 42. p 279 ff.

It was only by knowing his wretchedness that man could truly repent and so be prepared to receive the unspeakable mercy of God's grace.⁴ Andrewes accused Rome of perverting "the order" of salvation by teaching "the Gospel before the Law".⁵ As he insisted "doubtless, humbling cometh first".⁶

Partly because of its function as a pastoral tool the law and its 'use' became for the godly brethren a shibboleth of true religion. In 1567 the "humble brethren" of Geneva when touching only "one point" of controversy noted how Deuteronomy, the sum of the law, "doth show

4. As Perkins' representative of the true Christian, Eusebius, said, affirming Bradford's dictum, "[T]he right way to go unto heaven is to sail by hell". ibid. p 366.

5. Andrewes, p 71.

6. ibid., p 73, cf. Greenham, p 422.

sufficiently who they be that hold the true religion".⁷ Perkins, advising on discerning true religion in the midst of "manifold dissensions" recommended that the believer give his heart to God and "obey him in all his commandments".⁸

In this context the Decalogue became an attractively simple evangelistic tool as a summary of the law.⁹ Since the Elizabethan settlement, the Decalogue had increased in prominence in the church itself and in its liturgy.¹⁰

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7. John Calvin, The Sermons of M. Iohn Calvin vpon the Fifth Booke of Moses called Deuteronomie, Translated, A. Golding, London, 1583, in sig iiiiv.

Note: They are not speaking of "Turks, Jews" and "Saracens" but "of the nations which have long time born the renown of Christianity".
ibid.

8. Perkins, p 323.
Andrewes said that "the preaching of the Law ... is a mean to enable us to withstand the crafty and subtle suggestions of sin and Satan".
Andrewes, p 329.
9. cf. a later Sabbatarian George Widley, referred to the Decalogue as an abridgement of the Law "by God himself" "for the help of man's memory".
George Widley, The Doctrine of the Sabbath, London, 1604, p 1.
10. The Queen ordered popish ornaments in chancels to be replaced by the Two Tables of the Law. Recitation of the Decalogue became part of the litany.
Solberg, op cit, p 34.

Nowell's catechism, which relied heavily on Calvin's Geneva Catechism,¹¹ changed Calvin's order of exposition so as to expound the Decalogue first of all.¹² Greenham's catechism like most English catechisms of the period, followed suit.¹³

Anxious "not ... to repose any part of God's worship or of salvation in the [corrupted] doctrines and doings of men" the godly sought "pure rules of His worship"¹⁴ that they might stay on the narrow path and have "sure grounds of [their] salvation".¹⁵ Accordingly the first table of the Decalogue¹⁶ - the first four Commandments dealing directly with God's worship - came under closest scrutiny.¹⁷ It was those Commandments which man had most frequently disobeyed. For whereas the Commandments of the second table, which proscribed various forms of civil disobedience, had been implicitly accepted by all nations in their civil laws, the first table Commandments were "more contrary to the judgement of man merely natural",¹⁸ and so God had

11. Peter Jensen, "The Life of Faith in the Teaching of Elizabethan Protestants", D.Phil Thesis, Oxford, 1979, p 59.

12. ibid., p 90.

13. ibid., Chapter 5, and cf. Greenham, p 401-442.

14. Greenham, p 404.

15. ibid.

16. ibid., p 304.

17. Of the Ten Commandments - it was they "which immediately do bind us to our God".
ibid., p 368. cf. p 335.

18. ibid., p 304.

set them out at greater length and "fenced"¹⁹ them by giving man reasons to obey them.

Thus the length of the individual Commandments could be relevant to their importance. The Second Commandment prohibiting idolatry was particularly important as a shibboleth of true religion against popery. Because man was so prone to disobey it, Bownde explained that it had been expounded at greater length and "fortified"²⁰ with more reasons than all the other Commandments except one; the Fourth Commandment.

Once convinced of the usefulness of the Sabbath we can see how the Sabbatarians might have come to regard the Fourth Commandment as very important. For it was the longest commandment of them all.

19. Andrewes, p 325.

20. Bownde, p 3.

III

The rest of this chapter will deal with the attractions of Sabbatarianism as a social policy, and to do that we need to understand the brethren's diagnosis of social evil. The specific evils they saw were not looked at in isolation but regarded as specific symptoms of a disease in the body politic¹ which sprang from "the root of human frailty and corruption", i.e. sin.²

It was a commonplace amongst the brethren that they had fallen into "evil days".³ But, as Bownde put it in 1604, the sins of "hatred, malice, cruelty, oppression ... and all kinds of uncleanness ... and wantonness" could be "pas[t] by ... though they be very great", because he wanted his contemporaries to "look but to this one thing" - the cause of the problem - "the general contempt of God's holy word".⁴ One major symptom of that was widespread

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1. cf. P Collinson, Archbishop Grindal: 1519- 1583, University of California, 1979, pp 31-2.
 2. Hooker, op cit., [3:7], p 15. The extract coming from an anti-puritan pen like Hooker's illustrates the broad currency of the idea. cf. Andrewes, p 358-359.
 3. Bownde, sig A2 v. Sprint, op. cit., sig A2 v. cf. Greenham, p 367.
 4. Nicholas Bownde, The Holy Exercise of Fasting, Cambridge, 1604, p 308,9, (my emphasis).

profanation of the Sabbath. Many people regarded it as a day of recreation rather than worship.

While the brethren disapproved of some of the excesses of the wealthy,⁵ they were much more scandalised by the profanities of popular culture. "[I]dle and fruitless" common pastimes drew people away from God's worship. And there were "a thousand abominations more".⁶ People used their leisure time to gamble, to sing lewd songs, and much worse, to partake in gruesome carnivals of the flesh: "Bearbaitings, Bullbaitings, Cockfightings, and such like".⁷ Some festivities like Maygames nurtured peoples superstitions.⁸

In addition, popular entertainments were growing in sophistication. As well as 'interludes' using improvised venues, a number of permanent theatres had recently been erected in London. As well as nursing "whoredom, and uncleanness", and stealing "great flocks of miserable

5. Bownde, p 132.

6. ibid., pp 133, 134. (Bownde's emphasis).
cf. C Haigh, "Puritan Evangelism in the Reign of Elizabeth I", English Historical Review, 92 (1977), p 30, at pp 51-52.

7. ibid., (Bownde's emphasis).

8. ibid., p 135.

ignorant people from the holy ministry", they were commonly associated with the plague.⁹ Like other abominations which promoted sin, they provoked God to visit England with plagues and other judgements.

As "T.W." explained in the 1570's:

the cause of plagues is sin ...and
the cause of sin are plays:
therefore the cause of plagues are 10
plays.

This mentality had already produced a series of tirades against popular entertainments and profanations of the Sabbath.¹¹ The feelings which provoked such

9. Henry Holland, Spiritvall Preservatives against the Pestilence, London, 1593, sig Av v., Avi, r.

10. J Payne Collier, The History of English Dramatic Poetry ... and the Annals of the Stage, London, 1831, p 230, n.

As well the theatres were suspected of contributing to physically spreading infection by attracting large crowds.

11. See for example:

John Northbrooke, A Treatise Wherein Dicing, Dauncing ... on the Sabboth Day, are Reproved ..., London, 1577.

Philip Stubbes, The Anatomie of Abuses, London, 1583.

John Stockwood, A Sermon Preached at Paule's Crosse 24. of August. 1578., London, 1578.

See also Hill, Society, Chapter 5, Part VI, passim.

and Solberg, op cit., pp 49-55.

tirades would have been particularly keenly felt when the plague worsened.

At a crucial time in our story, 1592, a terrible plague swept London. Perkins claimed that almost 2,000 people had died from it per week.¹² It was the first visitation on such a scale for thirty years.¹³ In 1593 Henry Holland, Greenham's friend and literary executor, pointed to the recent national famine of 1587, the attack of the Armada, and the 1592 plague. He seemed to suggest that God's displeasure and wrath were increasing.¹⁴

And despite England's sinful state the means for cutting down sin had improved little. By the 1590 s

12. Perkins, p 282.

Keith Thomas says 15,000 people died in London.
Religion and the Decline of Magic, London, 1971, p 7.

13. Thomas, loc. cit..

14. Holland, op cit., sig. 21 r.

Similarly introducing his Doctrine of the Sabbath Bownde drew attention to the "heavy and unknown judgements" visited by the ravages of 1594's weather.

Bownde, sig A4 v.

despite three decades of established Protestantism, improvements in clerical standards had been slight.¹⁵ Preaching was the "most principal and proper means to beget faith"¹⁶ and so cut down sin but non-preaching and non-resident ministers still abounded.¹⁷ That meant the large scale "murder" of souls.¹⁸ Even where preaching had improved, public indifference meant that it often did little good.¹⁹ George Gifford believed that in many English towns there were no more than two or three people who "zealously" embraced the Gospel.²⁰

15. See particularly:
Hill, Society, pp 52-3.
but also:
Haigh, op cit., p 32.
and
Porter, op cit., p 225.

16. Greenham, p 405.
cf. Perkins p 214.
Bownde pp 173, 277.

Perkins described the want of preaching and hearing as "one of the great curses of God on earth".

Perkins, p 316.

17. Bownde, p 173.

18. Chadwick on non-resident pluralists living at Cambridge neglecting their flock.

Porter, p 137.

19. Perkins, p 34, and see opening paragraph of Chapter 3, Section IV, p 75, on 'the difference of hearers'.

20. Wallace, loc. cit., p 37.

In the year following the terrible 1592 plague Perkins praised the love God had shown England by calling it "out of the darkness, first of heathenism and then of popery". He contrasted that love with the "sin, ... rebellion, and ... disobedience" with which it had been requited.²¹ And, consistent with his view that things were still deteriorating,²² he believed that the winds of God's final judgement had "already begun to blow".²³

21. Perkins, p 292.

22. see supra., p 21, n.2, citing Perkins, p 22.
and see also Perkins, p 34.

23. ibid. p 297.

Note in this context, Lamont's observation that such "eschatological preconceptions pervaded English intellectual life". Perkins was in the mainstream of 'intellectual life'. He was hardly part of a 'lunatic fringe'.

William M Lamont, Godly Rule: Politics and Religion, 1603-60, London, 1969, p 8.

The brethren saw an indispensable role for the Church of England in tackling the two related problems which have been our themes so far; doctrinal plurality and the abominations of the age.

Although the church had no infallible "judicial" authority to determine its "own sense" of the scriptures,¹ it nevertheless played a crucial role in determining true doctrine. Its role was to interpret scripture to recover its true meaning as a lawyer recovers the true sense of the law.² Whereas the private opinion of even the soundest divine was liable to error,³ "in the church" the "godly learned" were "said to have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil ... true Apostles and false".⁴

1. Perkins, Works, III, p 394.

2. The Church was to interpret scripture, not according to the "unwritten traditions" of Rome, but "by comparing scripture with scripture ... as the lawyer gives the sense of the law, not from any judicial power given unto him above the law, but by observing the words with the scope & circumstances of the law".

ibid.

3. Perkins, p 37.

4. Perkins, Works III, p 265.

And so the Church was a reassuring bulwark against the potential anarchy of myriad private views.⁵ In this role, Andrewes explained that the church's "knowledge" had a "political use" in guiding the commonwealth. For "the want of knowledge is it, that bringeth the foundations of the earth, all the laws, out of course".⁶

And in coalition with the state,⁷ the church was able, indeed it was duty bound, to suppress all false doctrine and worship.⁸ Although the godly brethren were perfectly

5. It was to God's true churches "whose testimony we must rather cleave, than to the opinion of a few private men".

ibid.

6. Andrewes, p 358.

7. Bownde, p 276.

8. ibid., 278, cf. Sabbathvm, sig A2 v.

aware that the true Christian obedience to which they exhorted their congregation did not "pertain ... so much to ... outward celebration" and could not be "wrought by statutes"⁹ they nevertheless conceived for the Prince the role of "Doctores Genitum". The Prince must "look over the soul" of his subjects¹⁰ and lead them to the truth. One of God's great mercies upon England was that because of such a coalition between Church and State true religion was not simply "barely allowed but even, as it were, thrust upon men".¹¹ And that view underscored the attractiveness of Sabbatarianism as a social policy for the unregenerate.

9. Andrewes, p 357.

10. ibid.

11. Perkins, 293. No doubt Perkins wanted to see more successful 'thrusting' of religion on people. Nevertheless this does not affect my argument here.

Naturally most of the worst abominations of England would not be solved by exhortations to godliness. The Fourth Commandment became particularly attractive because it could easily be interpreted as a simple divine social program with two important components. Firstly it embodied a command to eradicate the profanities about which the godly were so concerned, many or most of which took place during people's spare time, on the Sabbath. Just as Henry Holland had stressed to London's Lord Mayor that "the rotten proud sins of this city ... are corrigable by good laws"¹² so the Fourth Commandment was a divine injunction to enact those laws at least in regard to the "enormities"¹³ of the weekly holiday.

12. Henry Holland, op cit., sig Av v.

13. Haigh, op cit., p 51.

Secondly, the Fourth Commandment was a divine remedy for popular religious indifference. It strengthened the obligation upon those in authority to 'thrust' religion on men by compelling them to "stoop ... at leastwise in the outward discipline of the church"¹⁴ on the Sabbath. So Bownde enjoined

all ... in highest authority, to
provide that laws be enacted for the 15
preservation of this rest.

This would prevent "a great many sins" and preserve the commonwealth from many punishments.¹⁶ The Sabbatarians sought to utilise the whole web of authority in their society urging "Masters in their families, Magistrates in their precincts, and Princes in their Realms" to

cause them that are under their
government, not only to rest upon the
Sabbath, but also and especially to 17
bestow [it] ... in God's service.

14. Bownde, p 276.

The two planks of the Sabbatarian platform as a social policy are captured best by Sprint.

Sprint. sig A2 v. quoted at p 124, note 6.

15. Bownde, p 94, (his emphasis).

16. ibid.

17. Bownde, Sabbathvm, sig A2 r.

Bownde, p 281.

The whole point of civil authority was that, in such matters, those in subjection should not be left to their own choice.¹⁸ Coercion would sometimes bring the reprobate to godliness.¹⁹ If it did not, the unregenerate, would be left "without excuse",²⁰ and those precious commodities, order and comeliness within the church and commonwealth would be better maintained.²¹

The 'magistrate' - both the Queen herself and petty magistrates - had not responded particularly well to previous exhortations to compel the people to better Sabbath observance. As recently as 1585 the Queen had vetoed a bill to enforce better Sabbath observance, which had passed two enthusiastic Houses.²²

18. ibid.

19. Bownde gives examples of how exhortations, admonitions and chastisements from authority might engender not simply outward obedience, but inward obedience.

ibid. p 261.

20. ibid., p 17.

21. As Andrewes says in a somewhat different context, "confusion and breach of order" is "a thing which GOD misliketh".

Andrewes, p 330, (his emphasis).

22. J E Neale, Elizabeth I and Her Parliaments : 1584 1601, London, 1957, pp 58-9.

And despite existing statutes prohibiting many 'sins' of the time like 'idleness' [vagrancy] and absenteeism from church, godly men had complained for many years that they were poorly executed by petty magistrates.²³ Bownde made

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23. With the reader's indulgence I quote Northbrook at rather greater length than I need to.

Queen Elizabeth in the xiiij and xvij years of her gracious reign, two Acts were made for idle vagrant and masterless persons, that used to loiter, and would not work, should for the first offence have a hole burned through the gristle of one of his ears an inch compass. And for the second offence committed therein, to be hanged.

If these and such like laws were executed justly, truly, and severely (as they ought to be) without any respect of persons favour or friendship, this dung and filth of idleness would easily be rejected and cast out of this commonwealth, there would not be so many loitering idle persons, so many Ruffians, Blasphemers, and Swing Bucklers, so many Drunkards, Tossepots, Whoremasters, Dancers, Fiddlers and Minstrels, Diceplayers, and Maskers, Fencers, Thieves, Interlude players, Cutpurses, ... Masterless servants, Jugglers, Rogues, sturdy Beggars, counterfeit Egyptians etc. as there are, nor yet so many plagues to be amongst us as there are if these dunghills and filth in commonweals, were removed, looked unto, and clean cast out, by the industry, pain, and travail of those that are set in authority and have government.[!]

Northbrook, op.cit., p 51.

the same complaint²⁴ but as Greenham said "many exhortations" concerning the Sabbath had fallen "to the ground" because people were "not convinced" of the doctrine of the Sabbath.²⁵

The Sabbatarian strategy, like that of earlier puritan writings, involved an attempt to constrain the discretion of the magistrate by showing that the particular action required was not simply a desirable "thing indifferent"²⁶ but something enjoined by "the precise commandment of God".²⁷ But, as we shall see in the following section, by the 1590's the godly brethren would have had to revise what hopes they had, of reforming the church, and the country's ungodly state through those in civil authority.

24. Bownde, p 279. Elsewhere Bownde stressed that if magistrates would not execute judgement, God would do it for them.

ibid. p 131.

25. Greenham, p 303.

26. Bownde, p 260.

27. ibid., p 280.

An analogous claim was made by Presbyterian Francis Johnson, in 1589, who argued for Presbyterianism "that this form of government is prescribed and commanded by the word of God" and "no other form of government is to be allowed".

Porter, op cit., p 141-2.

By the 1590 s the legislative and particularly the executive arm of the Elizabethan government was manifestly more antagonistic towards puritan ideas than it had ever been before. Elizabeth had resolutely denied Parliament's authority to address religious questions, vetoing a series of bills for religious reform.

More importantly the 1590's saw the destruction of the 'classis' movement, by which puritan clerics had hoped to bring the English church closer to the presbyterian model.¹ Many of the godly had pinned their hopes for a more godly England on presbyterian church government. The godly

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1. See Collinson, Puritan Movement, Parts 5, 6, 7, 8, passim.

Collinson observes that after the anti-presbyterian offensive of the late '80s and early '90s the puritan star continued to wane at court and in Parliament. By 1597 "political puritanism", - meaning organised political agitation through Parliament and the court, for alterations in the law, particularly relating to church government - "was bankrupt".

ibid. pp 431, 444.

brethren we are studying were sympathetic towards much of the presbyterian cause.²

Given the circumstances it is not surprising that, as several historians have observed, the nature of puritanism seems to begin to change. With reformation of church government "temporarily abandoned, by tacit and ... almost universal consent" Collinson observes that "it was time to turn with vigour to the reformation of towns, parishes, families and individuals."³ The resulting "new puritanism", Hill tells us, emphasised ever more strongly preaching, household discipline and the observance of the Sabbath.⁴ Clearly if we are to understand Sabbatarianism we must understand something of this new puritanism of which it formed a part. While many scholars have affirmed the shift of emphasis away from 'political puritanism' to 'new' or 'godly' puritanism they have hitherto given us little with which to flesh out the psychology of the change. The writings of our subjects enable us to make a start.

2. Because of the length of this footnote it has been transferred to the Appendix.

3. ibid., p 432-3.

4. Hill, Society, p 502.

Today repudiation of the legitimacy of hostile authorities is often a part of the ideological baggage of reform and protest movements. Elizabethian presbyterians and their sympathisers however would, almost to a man, have had a deep respect for many of the organs of civil authority which had contributed to crushing their movement.⁵ Also a strong belief in divine providence would have added piquancy to the disillusion of presbyterian sympathisers. Presbyterian John Udall, when he prayed "Thy Kingdom come" believed he was praying for presbyterian church government.⁶

5. Note, I am not here commenting on their attitude to various church authorities. Even an 'extremist' like John Penry, though he spoke his mind to the Queen, nevertheless did not dispute her authority. Perkins wrote that although the punishments of our superiors might sometimes be unjust "yet we must suffer it, until we can get some lawful remedy". Likewise, Rogers thought that if his presbyterian colleagues had broken the law "that would bring another manner of grief with it".

Perkins, Works, I, p 51.

Rogers, Diary, p 87.

6. Collinson, Puritan Movement, p 353.

During the 1590s another presbyterian, Josias Nicols, had "trusted that our merciful God, pitying his church, would ... rais[e] up some means, to further his own cause".⁷ But by 1592 it was abundantly clear that presbyterianism was not, for the time being at least, God's "means" of furthering his own cause.

God's preaching ministers were the chief means by which the spiritual health of the commonwealth would be built up, but it was they who had been harrassed most.⁸ In 1589 Rogers despaired "[T]here is little hope of any better state to the church".⁹ When Bownde and Sprint spoke of these "evil days",¹⁰ probably they were not simply referring to England's sinfulness, but also to the "cutt[ing] down" of "those means which are seen to stop the cause of sin

7. Josias Nicols, The Plea of the Innocent, (1602), p 31.

8. cf. ibid., pp 171-4.

9. Rogers, Diary, p 84.

10. Sprint sig A2 v, Bownde, sig A2 v.

most":¹¹ godly preaching. Certainly that was what Rogers meant by "the iniquity of the time".¹²

Josias Nicols, looking back on those events, declared:

we finding the mighty winds and strong stream
against us, were fain to humble ourselves under¹³
God's mercy.

And having humbled themselves before His mercy they gave themselves over to his providence hoping for "a better time, when it should please His gracious wisdom" to enable presbyterianism to be established without civil disobedience by making "His own truth to ... move the minds of our superiors".¹⁴

11. Rogers, Diary, p 91.

12. ibid.

13. Nicols, op cit, p 34-5.

14. ibid.

Using Roger's diary we may suggest that the heavy emphasis on inward religious experience characteristic of new puritanism was partly wrought by the trials of the 1580s and '90s. Rogers rejoiced to think that:

whatsoever they brought to pass to the impairing of
mine outward estate, yet ... they could not take from
me my chief treasure, my confidence in God. 19

We can detect in Greenham's and Bownde's published writings a similar shift of emphasis, away from presbyterian controversies towards personal godliness and the kindred issues of new puritanism. There is an impatience with those who "preposterously labour to reform the Church, that have no care to reform themselves".²⁰

19. ibid. p 93.

20. Bownde, p 279.

Similarly Greenham scolds the "many" who:

meddle and stir much about a new church
government, which are ... barren in the doctrine
of new birth

Greenham, (1612), p 48, aphorism 56, cf. ibid. p 797.

Greenham thought that too heavy a preoccupation with church government, whilst the aim might be worthwhile, could seduce the reformer from more immediate issues.²¹ Again the idea has its echo in Bownde who seeks to come to terms with the limitations placed upon reformation by an unsympathetic magistrate. He points out that improvements in the ministry, and greater legislative and administrative vigour in compelling church attendance are worthy goals, but while they were "more carefully laboured after" such labour could be at the expense of what could otherwise be done for the Church using available means.²²

With reformation by the magistrate out of the question, for the time being, the Sabbatarians urged their godly readers to do as Rogers had done when suspended. Where Rogers had prepared himself to do "any good which my [new] place may yield",²³ Bownde urged on his readers the duty to use "this that we have"²⁴ rather than expending too much energy on the futilities, of 'political puritanism'.

21. Greenham, (1612), p 48, aphorism 56.

22. Bownde, p 279.

23. Rogers, p 90.

24. Bownde, p 279.

As Rogers had responded to suspension by seeking "as far as I shall be able, to regard mine own profiting and the people's, with some clearer glorying of my God",²⁵ so Greenham reminded readers of the good which could redound to the nation from their renewed personal commitment to godliness.

We are wont to ascribe the afflictions of the church or commonwealth, the defect of right discipline and government to the magistrates, when rather ... our²⁶ own sins have begot such fruits.

The Sabbatarians' approach to Sabbath observance reflects the same attitude. While they sought to enlist the aid of those in authority to impose the doctrine of the Sabbath upon the reprobate, they conceived their treatises as manuals for the godly.²⁷

25. Rogers, p 92.

26. Greenham, (1612) p 53, aphorism 18 cf. Hooker, op cit., [3.6-7], p 15.

27. Greenham felt "most care" towards those who were "in the Church of God with us".

Greenham, p 301.

cf Rogers, Treaties, sig B2 v.

They reproved those "that labour for more means to sanctify the Sabbath, and are careless in practicing those that they have".²⁸ And believing that the Lord's providence would deliver the church "when it is most weak in itself"²⁹ Bownde urged the godly to better Sabbath observance to bring forward "such good blessings as God might" by those means "bestow upon his church".³⁰

Indeed, the Sabbatarians were at pains to show the godly how they could use the Sabbath to deepen their religious experience and help their efforts to godliness. That is the theme of the next chapter.

28. Bownde, p 279.

29. ibid. p 227.

30. ibid., p 279.

CHAPTER 3

PERSONAL PIETY: PROBLEMS AND RESPONSE

Sabbatarianism for the godly.

The puritan understanding of a number of Protestant doctrines heightened the tension between man's duty to God and his ability to perform that duty. In addition to abandoning reassuringly concrete Catholic rituals, puritan teachings seemed to require purer faith and greater zeal from the believer. Sabbatarianism was, amongst other aspects of the new puritanism, an attempt to resolve this tension because it presented a concrete routine by which the sinner could regularly take stock of his failings, disburden his conscience of guilt and, (partly by nurturing the comforts available to him in his religion), stir himself to greater godliness. To show how Sabbatarianism was a response to that problem, it is necessary to explain the problem more fully.

The Catholic had many concrete aids to faith. He could confess his sins and be told of their absolution. He had sacred objects and rituals¹ which offered a concrete and reassuring sense of God's presence. The puritan saw the Catholic attribution of sacredness to objects and ceremonies as idolatrous. So also were Catholic devotional exercises to strengthen the will, because they worshipped God with acts wrought of man's will; with "fruits of the flesh", not the spirit.²

For the godly puritan the most concrete manifestation of God was the "feel" of God's spirit "working in him".³ But he could not feel the spirit directly. He could only observe its "testimony"⁴ - its "peculiar working and effects" - within him.⁵

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1. Like the rosary and the sign of the cross to name just two.
 2. Rogers, Treatises, sig. B[1] r.
 3. Greenham, p 95. Note irregular pagination. This is the p 95 appearing on sig. G6 r.
 4. Perkins, p 257.
 5. Greenham, p 95. (sig. G6 r.).

Those effects were in Paul's terminology the "fruits" of the spirit: those godly attributes of disposition like love, joy and peace, and good works wrought of them.⁶ Accordingly fruit and fruitfulness were at the heart of the Christian experience. It was "By the fruits we are to know the reality of faith".⁷

In addition to this more 'abstract' piety, many demands on the puritan believer were intensified. Firstly in the Catholic schema human effort coalesced with God's grace and the action of His spirit to effect godliness in the believer. For the Protestant, Gods grace

6. Gal 5:22. Fruits of the spirit in this citation include only the attributes of disposition though certainly the puritans regarded works born of the godly disposition as fruits of the spirit.

7. Greenham , in Knappen, Tudor Puritanism, p 394, citing Greenham, (1612), p 375.

was the only effectual source of godliness. Thus where the Catholic could take comfort, and feel virtue in resisting temptation, for the Protestant, while it was obviously better not to succumb to it, the very existence of the feeling of being tempted itself, spoke of the action of the flesh 'choking' the spirit.

In addition the puritans emphasised that the liberty given to Christians setting them free from outward ceremonies, was granted that they might worship God better. Christian liberty strengthened the obligation upon the believer to "attend the greater things of the law of God"⁸ and obtain spiritual fruits. Thus Greenham's former resident pupil, godly preacher Henry Smith, stressed to his

8 Edmund Bunny in Peter Jensen, "The Life of Faith in the teaching of Elizabethan Protestants" D.Phil Thesis, Oxford, 1979, p 168. Note Bunny is not here talking about the benefits of Christian liberty but rather bemoaning the failure of Catholicism to properly teach Christian liberty.

hearers the Pauline injunction "so run that thou mayest obtain".⁹ In Greenham's terms freedom from the outward strictures of the Jewish ceremonial law enhanced the Christian's obligation to obey the eternal moral law.¹⁰ We can see why Perkins spoke in a way which might at first seem enigmatic to us, of "Christian liberty by which we are admonished to sundry duties".¹¹

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9. 1 Cor 9:24.
In Henry Smith, The Works of Henry Smith, 2 Vols., 1866, Edinburgh, Vol. 1, p 322.

Smith repeats the dose six times.

That is: so seek that thou mayest find;
so ask that thou mayest obtain; so knock that
it may be opened; so give that thou
mayest do good; so suffer that thou
mayest have comfort; so hear that
thou mayest profit.

ibid.

10. Accordingly that part of the moral law requiring sanctification of the Sabbath was "more straightly required of us than of [the Jews]", because, stripped of its ceremonial strictures, "it is more clearly set forth to us than to them".

Greenham, (1612), p 811.

11. Perkins, Works, I, p 540, cf. ibid., II, 308.
cf. John S Coolidge, The Pauline Renaissance in England, Oxford, 1970, p 26, where Coolidge claims that "The Puritan thinks of Christian liberty less as a permission than as a command".

The Christian was not simply freed from things which were peripheral to true religious experience. As Henry Smith explained, such "cares", though they might appear to help build the temple, in fact did the opposite because, like Catholic outward ceremonies, they took "all the time from that which we should do, and disable us to do it".¹² And because the Christian must have "no care but the care to please [God]"¹³ the godly envisaged a sharp dichotomy between spiritually useful activity and unfruitfulness. Whatever was not fruitful was positively harmful,¹⁴ or as

12. Smith, op cit., Volume I, p 394. cf. Bishop Jewell in Jensen op cit., p 150.

13. Smith, loc cit.

14. cf. Coolidge suggests op cit., p 47 where commenting on earlier puritans he suggests their view was that "whatever does not build destroys" with no intermediate possibility appearing.

Smith put it "every care which is not of God, is of Satan".¹⁵

The godly life became a constant search for spiritual fruit or profit. Thus Rogers' errand of mercy "visit[ing] 2 sick persons" was also a quest for fruit which was "not without profit" to himself.¹⁶ For, as he acknowledged anxiously "every part of my life ought to bear fruit".¹⁷

Such views give rise to a whole world of torments for the sinner who, like Rogers, had weaned himself from many of the grosser sins.¹⁸ Those inevitable periods of "dullness, unprofit, earthlymind, wandr[ing] ..." ¹⁹ which are recorded on almost every page of Roger's diary, became the mortal enemy.

15. Smith, loc. cit., cf. "Conscience is either good or bad."
Perkins, Works, I, p 538.

and Greenham on the human mind "continually grinding out either good or evil".

Greenham, (1612), p 52, aphorism 9.

16. Rogers, Diary, p 56.

17. ibid., p 88.

18. ibid., p 57.

19. ibid., p 72, cf. p 56.

In addition the Protestant doctrine of predestination wrought its own unique psychological ravages. Once converted the sinner must, on pain of damnation, grow in piety for, as Rogers aphorism had it, "if we grow not, we began but counterfeitly".²⁰

And some seeking complete assurance of election achieved "nothing but doubting" and anxiety "because" they could always feel their "flesh lust[ing] against the spirit".²¹

20. Richard Rogers et.al. A Garden of Spirituall Flowers, London, 1610, sig A7 r.

cf. Perkins, p 324.

and Rogers, Spirituall Flowers, sig A8 r.

Note the sharp dichotomy between spiritual good and bad rears its head again as Perkins insists that "he which goes not forward goes backward".

Perkins, p 95.

21. Bownde, Vnbeliefe, p 147.

The abstractness of puritan piety and its heavy demands on the believer which have been explored in this section, meant that much puritan teaching "seem[ed] to propound faith unto men at so high reach, as few can attain".²² The rest of this chapter outlines how puritan pastoral theology responded to that problem.

22. Perkins, Works, I, p 606.

And note the questioner in Gifford's catechism who claims that "heaven and heavenly things are far above our reach", though it is less certain that he is referring to the problems of puritan piety.

Wallace, op cit., p 32.

The tension in puritan spirituality which we have explored, elicited several responses. Firstly, although the sinner could not do a good work, the language of the brethren often suggests that man could participate in some way in the drama being enacted within him between his flesh and the spirit. He was enjoined to "nourish the motions of God's spirit"¹ and "labour that it be not quenched".²

As well, the brethren began to develop their own aids to faith. In Jensen's words:

good works, prayer, sacraments, and discipline which at first had been regarded primarily as the results of faith and exercises of faith (however much the exercise may have confirmed faith), became the aids of faith. ³

1. Greenham, p 65.

2. ibid., p 93, (sig G5 r.) (my emphasis).
cf. Similar examples in Section IV of this chapter at pp 76, 81, 83 at notes 4, 21, 29, and see Perkins, p 259.

If people wish to describe this as tainting strict justification by faith and predestination with the impurity of justification by works and/or human free will, then so be it. I think I agree with them. The essential point here, however, the historical datum with which we are working, is that the godly brethren would not have regarded themselves as doing this. Accordingly I have not deliberated upon the point in the text.

3. Jensen op cit., p 204-5.

cf. Perkins, p 224 where though the Sacraments are a seal of faith they are also a "medicine to the diseased ... soul" which may "purify and heal" the heart".

Thus Perkins' true Christian Eusebuis uses "prayer and fasting, watching [introspection], deeds of mercy ... reading the scriptures" and other exercises as "means ... to weaken the flesh and strengthen the spirit".⁴ It was by such "means" or "helps"⁵ that the godly sought to stir themselves up from their frequent periods of spiritual dullness.⁶ Rogers diary gives us numerous practical examples.

4. Perkins, pp 373-4. (my exphasis).

5. Greenham, p 311; Rogers, Diary, p 58.

6. 'Stirrings up' to fruitfulness are a very regular feature of the writings of the brethren, and, judging from Roger's diary, their lives. Just a few examples follow in the text.

On Tuesday August 21, 1587, Rogers and his wife rode to London. Despite the very best intentions "to pass the time profitably" they "wander[ed] by little and little in needless speech" and fell into a "common course". And "Although ... there was no great default committed"⁷ Rogers believed that he had, to use Greenham's word, "choked" the spirit in him.⁸ Greenham warned that in such circumstances even the "most righteous ... may soon fall into great sins".⁹ And indeed Rogers did fear a further fall in "some ways".¹⁰ In such circumstances the sinner must "run so much faster forward" to reassure himself that the spirit still moved within him.¹¹ That is precisely what Rogers did. By fasting on his return from London, Rogers felt the relief and joy of being "well stirred up" and praised the Lord for

7. Rogers, Diary, p 58.

8. Greenham, p 104.

9. ibid.

10. Rogers, loc. cit..

11. Greenham, p 95 (sig G8 r.),
cf ibid., p 247.

such gracious helps".¹² As we shall see, for the Sabbatarians the Sabbath becomes just such a 'gracious help' for the godly.

In the 1580s there was a conspicuous absence of practical Protestant guides for living the godly life. In contrast, the pietistic emphasis of the Catholic mission

12. Rogers, loc. cit.,
cf. ibid., pp 89-90.

Interestingly Hooker identifies this as a distinctive trait of the brethren. Namely the belief that

it [is] exceeding necessary, for fear
of quenching that good spirit, to use
all means whereby the same may be ...
strengthened

Hooker, op cit., [3:12], p 18.

in England¹³ brought forth a series of devotional manuals. The contrast was underscored by the practice among Protestants of publishing bowdlerised 'Protestantised' versions of Catholic works.

When Protestant Edmund Bunny published a Protestant version of a Catholic devotional work, its author Robert Parsons, challenged him to name any Protestant who had "set forth (of themselves) any ... treatise of this kind".¹⁴

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13. Bossy comments that "the newcomers" of the Catholic mission in England of the 1570s and '80s "were concerned with the reformation of behaviour, with interior conversion and 'godly discipline'".

J Bossy, The English Catholic Community[:] 1570-1850, London, 1975, p 17.

NB. Prof. Williams made the point on one of my drafts that this pietism emerges after a period of repression in both Catholicism and puritanism.

14. In Jensen, op. cit. p 96.

From about this time - 1585 - a number of the godly brethren sought to fill the gap in Protestant literature to which Parsons had referred.¹⁵ Their response produced works of new puritanism.

When the brethren came to produce directories for the Christian life they stressed "the means which might ... preserve ... the ... health" of Christians' faith, and "those helps, which might ... recover ... them" from periods of unfruitfulness;¹⁶ such aids as the sacraments,¹⁷

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15. In 1587 a meeting of godly divines decided to "bring into writing a direction for our lives".

In the preface to the ensuing work, Seven Treatises, Rogers acknowledges that his motivation stems partly from the fact

that the Papists cast in our teeth, that we have nothing set out for the certain and daily direction of a Christian.

Rogers, Diary, p 69.

Rogers, Seven Treatises, sig A6 r.

16. Greenham, p 247.

17. eg. Perkins, 219 ff.

prayer¹⁸ and meditation.¹⁹ In addition the brethren provided routines like fasting for the programmed use of these means. As we shall see in the following section, the Sabbath became just such a program of godly helps and 'stirrings up'.

18. eg. Smith, op cit., Volume I, p 389 ff.

19. eg. Greenham, p 37 ff.

Just as Rogers had repeatedly lamented his "wandrings" so Bownde felt the torment of "that untowardness and inaptness, that is in [Man's] nature to all goodness".¹ which made it so difficult to give oneself wholly to the ways of the Lord. In addition to inherent human frailty, there were the positive hindrances to godliness presented by the distractions of this world. Lawful work at one's calling far from being decried, was insisted upon as necessary to salvation.² But as Rogers had privately lamented the "deceivable allurements" of the world could "utterly quail" spiritual fervour built up in holy exercises.³

1. Bownde, p 18.

2. Perkin's true Christian Eusebius included "bodily labour" as one of those "means" by which he could mortify his flesh and strengthen the hold of the spirit.

Perkins, p 374.

3. Rogers, Diary, p 89.

Calvin had articulated the same problem.

Now when the scripture speaketh of our
being sanctified unto God, it is to
separate us from all that which is
contrary to his worship and service.
But where shall one find such purity[?]:
We are in the world.

Calvin, X. Commandmentes., sig. fol 31 r.

And so the Sabbatarians, observing themselves and their flock, "continually drowned in the things of this world"⁴ and keenly abhorring the consequent unfruitfulness were strongly attracted to that use of the Sabbath which Calvin had already articulated. Using it, men could "separate" themselves as far as possible "from the defilements of the world, and of their own flesh".⁵ The idea of separation from the world was already fundamental. It formed part of the image of election itself⁶ and was also the beginning of sanctification.⁷

4. Bownde, p 13.

5. Calvin, X. Commandementes,. sig. fol 31 v.
cf. Andrewes description of the Sabbath as a "remedy
for distraction".

Lancelot Andrewes, The Pattern of Catechistical
Doctrine, London, 1650, p 265.

6. Perkins, p 225.

7. Andrewes, p 326.
cf. Calvin, X. Commandementes., sig. fol 31 r.

Liberated from "the cogitations, studies, delights and desires" of the world,⁸ the Christian would "never have all the means" of his worship and salvation "so plentifully and so continually, as upon the Sabbath".⁹ Thus conceived, the Sabbath became of of those "means" or for Greenham "the especial means" of God's worship.¹⁰ It was one of God's "necessary helps for religion".¹¹

The Sabbath was particularly attractive as a regular weekly routine. Bownde "pitifully" beheld those who, though they were "children of God", were nevertheless partly

8. Bownde, p 13.

9. ibid., p 239.

10. Greenham, p 321.

11. ibid., p 311.

distracted by their callings and partly by natural 'untowardness' "many times neglecting the public and private exercises of religion, ... in the weekdays".¹² Such practical considerations were important for the many laymen who feared that "they must follow the world, and let preaching go, or else ... beg".¹³ By doing what could be done only "in part" on weekdays "in whole" on the Sabbath¹⁴ believers could "supply ... the wants, which we have on the weekdays".¹⁵

The Sabbath's regularity had other attractions. One of the Catholic criticisms of Protestant spirituality was that without concrete rituals of purgation it offered the believer no satisfactory release from the guilt of sin.¹⁶

12. Bownde, p 18.

13. Gifford summarising popular views in the guise of his character Atheos.

Wallace, op cit., p 37.

14. Greenham, p 313.

15. Greenham, p 366.

16. Jesuit William Warford charged in 1604 that Protestantism, while it gave people "liberty to commit sin", afforded them no "remedy to be rid of it, nor means to disburden their conscience thereof".

Jensen, op cit., p 139.

One way Protestants had sought to tackle the problem was by way of regular routine. Perkins advocated self examination "[o]nce a day" by which the sinner could "keep a court in [his] conscience" to try his thoughts, words and deeds, and then be cleansed by truly repenting of his sins.¹⁷ Greenham too, believed that such regular self-examination and repentance were important "if not once a day, which were expedient", and which others¹⁸ had recommended, "yet once in the week at ... least".¹⁹ Bownde believed that the godly would become "most miserable, and ... like unto the rest of the world" if when "falling into many sins, prone unto a great many more ... there were no Sabbath at all"²⁰ by which they could stir themselves up.

17. Perkins, p 299.

18. Perkins as above, and also Rogers who developed a more comprehensive daily checklist which included introspection and repentance amongst sundry other exercises and/or duties.

Spirituell flowers, op cit. Sig Bl r.

19. Greenham, p 359.

20. Bownde, p 18.

So just as Rogers had thanked God for the help of fasting,²¹ Bownde saw the Sabbath as "the singular mercy of God" which, with His sacraments and word, was the only means for relieving the sinner from the guilt of his "own sins" and raising him from "the bottomless pit of all misery".²²

The Sabbatarian Sabbath also had some attraction as a public witness of godliness. Of course godly Catholics had many outward manifestations of their piety.²³ Significantly one of Bownde's reasons for promoting

21. at p 62, n.12 supra. Note also that both Andrewes and Bownde both wrote at some length about fasting.

See Andrewes, p 352 ff.

Bownde, of course wrote a whole book on the subject: Bownde, Fasting.

22. Bownde, p 17.

23. cf. Jensen, op cit., p 150.

Protestant fasting was to stop "our adversaries the papists ... boast[ing]" of their conspicuously pious fasting.²⁴ And it was widely recognised that conspicuous piety attracted "simple peoples" seeking "to be led in a right way".²⁵

Bownde does mention Sabbatarianism's potential as a "witness" of godliness,²⁶ though he does not give us evidence of Greaves "imperative" to visual manifestation

23. cf. Jensen, op cit., p 150.

24. Bownde, Fasting, p 36.
cf. Greenham, pp 361, 376.

25. Rogers, Treatises, sig A6 v.
cf. Hooker, op cit., [13:13] pp 18-19.

And note Hooker's accusation of conspicuous piety against "the brethren". at [3:12] p 18.

26. Bownde, p 46.
Bownde does also say "let us ... show ourselves Christians by keeping ... the Lord's day" though this is a quotation from Augustus.

Bownde, p 284.

of puritan piety.²⁷ For Greenham and Bownde the principal value of the Sabbath was to be found in its fruitful use. "[U]nless ... fruits ... follow upon it", it was to "no purpose".²⁸

27. Greaves, op cit., p 20.

By way of digression I note that it was a frequent criticism of Sabbatarianism that it was "set up out of faction to be a character of difference" between the godly and the ungodly. I mention this and cite examples of the criticism below in this note to show the social potential of Sabbatarianism. Obviously it would be imprudent to suggest that such examples reflect on the motives of Greenham or Bownde.

Fuller, cited by Whitaker op cit, p 63.

And see also:

J Sears McGee, The Godly Man in Stuart England, New Haven and London, 1976, p 120, n. 9.;

Peter Heylyn, The History of the Reformation..., 2 Vols., (Ecclesiastical History Society), Cambridge, 1849, Vol. I, p. cviii.

28. Bownde, pp 25, 24.

Before further exploring the godly Sabbath in the next section we may let Greenham summarise the themes of this section:

[S]leeping the Sabbath, day is the ... market day ... of the soul,²⁹ when men purely knowing the use of it, separate it wholly from other days, they ... may recover ... from sins ... past, arm themselves against sin to come,³⁰ grow in knowledge, increase in faith, and ... be strengthened in the ³¹ inner man.

29. cf. Andrewes, p 337, 339.

Bownde, p 188.

pace Porter, op cit., p 224.

30. cf. Andrewes, p 337.

31. Greenham, p 301.

As Elizabeth's reign progressed it became apparent that Protestant preaching was not as effective at propagating true religion as contemporay encomiums of preaching suggested.¹ Bownde lamented the "intolerable ignorance ... everywhere" despite "long preaching of the word".² Though he was sympathetic to many who complained about their minister, he admonished them nevertheless, to "consider whether some great part of the fault be not in themselves".³ For the Sabbatarians the solution was partly to be found in the use of the Sabbath to deepen the believer's religious experience. On that day the Christian

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1. Haigh, op cit., gives a general study of the problem in Lancashire. The problem itself was most succinctly expressed in 1614 by William Harrison.

People hear much, learn little and practice less.
Which cannot be imputed to the 'want of good
preaching, but rather to the want of good hearing.

in ibid., p 47.
cf., Perkins, p 34.

Greenham's ministry was the victim of the want of good hearing'. It is said that in his twenty year tenure in Dry Drayton he saw good done in only one family.

Porter, op cit. p 218.

2. ibid., p 197.
3. Bownde, p 200.

must "labour diligently to feel the fruit" of God's mercies and helps.⁴

In this section we further revise the view of the "gloomy" Sabbath, not simply to do our subjects justice, but to describe more accurately the 'experiential' Sabbath, to see how, given the tensions of puritan piety, believers could further their efforts to godliness and derive comfort from the Sabbatarian Sabbath. To do that we must understand the role of assurance in puritan piety. It has been only partially understood by many scholars.

The problem stems from seeing the question of assurance as something which was simply provoked by the doctrine of predestination, rather than something which was central to piety itself. The classic formulation is by Weber:

The question, Am I one of the elect must ...
have arisen for every believer ... forc[ing]₅
all other interests into the background.

4. Greenham, (1612), p 811.

5. Max Weber, The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism, Translated, Talcott Parsons, London, 1968, p 110.

Thus Watkins asserted recently that

Assurance was by no means necessary
for salvation and was, indeed,⁶ a
rare blessing of mature faith.

He was describing what Perkins refers to as "[t]he highest
degree of faith ... plerophoria, a full assurance".⁷

But both Perkins and Bownde pointed out that it was
precisely this understanding of assurance which could put
God out of "reach".⁸ Perkins insisted that "every faith

6. Owen C Watkins, The Puritan Experience, New York, 1972,
p 11.

7. Perkins, p 230.

cf., Greenham, p 63.

Similarly it is full assurance to which Allen refers.

Knappen, in my view quite rightly, rebels against the
emphasis placed on assurance by Weber and others, but
is somewhat unconvincing in accounting for "the space
given to this topic in the literature". I think he
does not give sufficient weight to a slightly
different form of assurance which I shall outline
presently.

Allen, op cit., p 229.

Knappen, in Rogers, Diary, pp 14-15.

8. Perkins, Works, I, p 606.
Bownde, Vnbeliefe, p 146-8.

be for his [sic] nature a certain persuasion, ... only the strong faith is the full persuasion".⁹ In this sense "certain persuasion" or "assurance" lay at the heart of all true faith, and, in fact, distinguished it from its bogus and corrupted forms. Whereas the unregenerate craved God's favour because of fear, and for relief from guilt, the godly, because of the motions of God's spirit within them, found "sweetness" and delight in His ways.¹⁰ That sweetness was the product of the sinner's personal relationship with God: a relationship characterised by his persuasion of "God's favour towards himself".¹¹ Such an experience would fashion his heart to love God out of gratitude, not fear. For the "sure persuasion" of the forgiveness of his sins effected an "unspeakable" joy in justification and

9. Perkins, loc. cit...

10. Greenham, p 100.

11. Perkins, p 155-56.

salvation and so a "peace of conscience, which ... passeth all understanding".¹² Delighting in God's ways, believers could worship Him as "free and voluntary people obeying God" in Christian liberty "as if there were no law to compel them".¹³ Without grasping hold of this liberty the sinner could only worship God with works of his own flesh offered up in the bondage of fear.¹⁴ He could never be saved.

In this sense assurance was central to faith, an incident of the sinner's belief that God was "at one"¹⁵ with him.¹⁶ "[F]aith joined with assurance of God's favour"

12. Greenham, p 93. (sig. G7 r.) NB: Punctuation in this quote has been altered.

13. Perkins, Works, II, p 217.

14. ibid., p 276.

Thus Perkins' otherwise paradoxical contrast between the "liberty" of "service and obedience" to God and the "spiritual bondage" of "disobedience".

Works, I, p 540.

15. Greenham, loc. cit.

16. Dering, a godly puritan of an earlier generation felt similarly strongly about this when he said "take away assurance, you take away the faith of God's elect." Jensen, op cit., p 111.

It was only by "belief or faith" which "hath assurance going with it" that the sinner could cleave to God and eternal life.

Rogers, Treatises, sig B[1] r. (my emphasis).

was "that alone"¹⁷ which enabled the believer to worship God in love and gratitude "in the liberty of the spirit".¹⁸ As Perkins said, assurance was that essential step in the religious experience by which the believer could "apply Christ and all his benefits unto himself".¹⁹

Assurance and delight were two different but mutually reinforcing aspects of the same religious experience. The joy and peace attained by the sinner upon feeling himself "at one" with God, further fashioned in him a love of God and so strengthened the delight found in his ways. That

17. Roger, Treatises, sig B[1] r. (my emphasis).

18. Greenham, p 101.

19. Perkins, p 155.

delight was itself the "warrant and testimony of the spirit"²⁰ and so, a source of assurance.

Thus Greenham affirmed that "we must learn ... to delight ourselves with the means of our salvation".²¹ For, as Perkins put it, just as "[w]hen the stomach refuses meats, it is sick ... when there is no delight or savour" in holy exercises - in this case reading God's word - "it argues the wickedness of the heart".²² It is no accident then that for Greenham, when the Christian is enjoined to sanctify the Sabbath he is commanded to do so by making it his "whole delight".²³

20. Greenham, p 93 (sig G7 r.),
cf. Perkins p 257.

21. Greenham, p 325.

22. Perkins, p 323,
cf. Rogers on the necessity of "delighting in ...
spiritual knowledge",
Treatises, p 150.

23. Greenham, p 411.
cf. Hill, Society, p 176, who is surprised by a
similar phrase in John Preston. In fact delighting in
the Sabbath is biblical. Isaiah 58:13.

Though it seems paradoxical, the frequent, regular and fierce²⁴ self examination advocated by the Sabbatarians was to nurture the believer's delight and assurance. Like the quest for assurance, introspection was not intended to be a fretful incident to faith provoked by the question of election, but rather something necessary to feeling one's relationship with God. For a true believer "doth feel ... the power of Christ in him".²⁵

Porter, observing Roger's frequent self examinations, assumes that he was constantly plagued with the question of his election and concludes that Roger's life was a "continual fret".²⁶ But we should remember that the man who exhorted Christians to regularly "rip and ransack" and search their hearts "unto the bottom"²⁷ as "a duty of

24. In such an examination the sinner must search for the "least sin". Bownde, Fasting, p 87.

25. Perkins, p 227.

26. Porter, op cit., p 220.

27. Perkins, p 289, cf. 287.

great moment and special necessity",²⁸ also enjoined them to "fight against all doubting and diffidence of [their] salvation".²⁹

Introspection was to be performed not only with a view to discovering sin,³⁰ but also to gain "comfort" from ones progress, through God's mercies.³¹

28. ibid., p 288.

29. ibid., p 259.

30. Rogers, Diary, p 62.

31. ibid., p 61.

For example Rogers notes with "some comfort"

that I have been better in watchfulness
about my heart and life ... And surely God hath
been merciful to me ... to awake me again
when I have been declining ... to offer me
occasions many ways of continuance by good
company, as Cul[verwel]. So that I must needs
with admiration say, Oh Lord how wonderful
are thy mercies.

ibid.

Where self examination brought the discovery of sin, that was not necessarily a cause for anxiety, it was an opportunity for the sinner to humble himself "but yet without dreadful and deadly despairing".³² Only by continual humbling could the sinner "continually make a renovation" of his original conversion,³³ as required.

And as Greenham put it

it is an undoubted earnest of our
regeneration, and happy are we if we
find ourselves so ... troubled
with our sins. 34

Introspection then, even if it was provoked by anxiety, was conceived to be a source of assurance and comfort.³⁵

32. Rogers, Treatises, sig A5 v.

33. Perkins, p 310.

34. Greenham, p 269.

35. cf. Bownde, Fasting, p 96, which is cited in the text on p 94 at note 17.

We can turn Porter's interpretation of Rogers' fretfulness on its head. Because "the more a man doth feel the burden of his sins, the greater measure of grace ... he hath",³⁶ Rogers' execrations of his own sinfulness are more likely to have been a source of assurance than the product of doubt.³⁷ Abhorrence of sin was, as much as its obverse, delight in Gods ways, testimony of the spirit and a source of assurance. Thus the Sabbatarian was to

36. Perkins, Works, II, p 375.
cf. Perkins, p 402-3.

37. Note also in this context what we have already noted: namely Rogers' "chief treasure", his unshakeable "confidence in God".

This sounds to me like full assurance. Porter acknowledges Rogers' full assurance but sustains his interpretation by arguing firstly that one could lose assurance in practice "if not in dogma", and secondly that Rogers' "full assurance" was a "reward" for "progress". The trouble with this is that one of Porter's examples of Rogers fretting over his election occurs earlier in his diary than an example which is taken to illustrate his "full assurance"!

My interpretation better incorporates the coexistence of protestations of one's assurance and execrations of ones own sinfulness.

Rogers, Diary, p 93.

Porter, op.cit., p 220-1.

examine himself for his sins and also for "the gifts of God, received" that he might humble himself for the one "and be thankful for the other". Ideally both processes nurtured the believer's relationship and confidence in God, making other acts of worship more "precious" and "effectual".³⁸

Indeed the comfort to be had in assurance is a major theme which ties together Sabbatarianism and various other incidents of new puritanism emerging at the time.

Given the tensions and anxieties of puritan piety, and the importance attached to the believer's assurance in "applying" God's promises to himself, one of the brethren's major pastoral tasks involved convincing many a "troubled and perplexed soul" that "mercy belongs to it". This was accomplished by bringing "the party in distress ... within the compass of the promise of salvation".³⁹ By interpreting the godly life as a quest for the full assurance which was available to so few, scholars have often underestimated the importance of the comfort which attended weaker forms of assurance.

38. Greenham, p 362.

39. Perkins, Works II, p 25.

Knappen suggests that one goal of the 'new puritan' attention to the process of conversion and election was to spur "sluggish Christians" to greater efforts to piety by fuelling their anxieties over election.⁴⁰ Rogers hoped his Seven Treatises might have that effect,⁴¹ but his principal purpose was "not ... to [address] the unreformed". Enough had already been written seeking to stir them to godliness.⁴² Rather, his main goal was to comfort the godly by showing "who they are which ... may rest satisfied in His promises, against all dreadful fear and doubt". It was essential to ensure that "God's children [not] be deprived of that which is their own";⁴³ assurance. Only that could "bring forth fruits of amendment of life" rather than abominable will works.⁴⁴ Thus Bownde's Vnbeliefe of St Thomas was written to encourage believers to acknowledge

40. Knappen, Tudor Puritanism., pp 394-5.

41. Rogers was happy to disabuse "loose livers" of any false confidence they might have of their election, "which belongeth not to them".

Rogers, Treatises, sig B2 r.

42. ibid., sig B2 v.

43. ibid., sig B2 r.

44. ibid., sig B[1] r.

and nourish "such a measure" of assurance as they had, so that they might "abandon distrustfulness" and cease to despair over their inability to achieve full assurance.⁴⁵ Perkins described the lowest "degrees of true faith" with precisely the same motive: to "rectify" those teachings which, by equating true faith with full assurance, seemed to put faith at "so high a reach".⁴⁶ And where new puritan Perkins expounded degrees of faith "that the weak ones, to their comfort, may be truly informed of their estate",⁴⁷ Sabbatarian Greenham exhaustively set out the "heavenly variety" of Sabbath exercises⁴⁸ in which the believer could "thrive, ... that the most weak may", by finding exercises in which he could delight, "comfort his conscience".⁴⁹

45. Bownde, Vnbeliefe, p 147-8.

46. Perkins, Works, I, p 606, (my emphasis).

47. ibid., (my emphasis).

48. See the next section for an exposition of Sabbath exercises.

49. Greenham, pp 368, 369, (my emphasis). Here I am using Greenham's attribution of motives to God, to describe his own motives.

These 'delightful' and comforting aspects of the Sabbatarian Sabbath underscore the fact that the Sabbatarians, aware of their contemporary reputation as 'precisians',⁵⁰ sought to advocate a lifestyle which, though it was not corrupted by fleshy libertinism or superstition, they saw as nevertheless comfortable, dignified, joyous and moderate.⁵¹ With that in mind we can further explore Sabbatarian piety in the next section.

50. Greenham, p 304.

51. Perkins for instance described his own position on the Sabbath as a moderate "mean between ... two extremities" though he agreed with all the major theological arguments of the Sabbatarians.

Perkins, Works, p 109.

Like some of their new puritan brethren, the Sabbatarians were at some pains to show that the lifestyle they advocated was not excessively difficult or dour. Rogers hoped that his foray into 'new puritanism' would bring the "Christian life" into "greater account with many, who think it (through error) overburdensome".¹ And as Smith sought to reassure the uninitiated that "prayer seems a harder thing than it is",² so, on several occasions Bownde reassured his readers that Sabbatarianism was less burdensome than it might seem. More than once he quoted 1 Timothy 4:8 stressing the advantages of godliness in this life.³ Because God's providence would ensure that "God in this life will sufficiently minister unto all our wants",⁴

1. Rogers, Treatises, sig A6 r.

That is why he set down 'helps' and

the manifold ... prerogatives, which God hath bequeathed to his people to hearten them on, ... and to make the Christian life easy..

ibid., sig. B4 r. (my emphasis).

2. Smith, op cit., Vol. I, p 401.

3. 1 Timothy 4:8 reads "... godliness is profitable unto all things, having promise of the life that now is, and of that which is to come". (King James version).

Bownde, pp 99, 272 and again in his Treatise Fvl of Consolation, Cambridge, 1608, p 179.

4. Greenham, p 109. Greenham's words are used to illustrate his agreement on the point, then I revert to Bownde.

anyone might rest on the Sabbath without suffering financially.⁵ Elsewhere he insisted that masters would not find themselves without good servants if they insisted on their Sabbath observance; that it was "a great wickedness to think that the Lord" would "drive them to such inconveniences"!⁶

Because Bownde did not want to present his position, as overburdensome or excessively 'precise' he disavowed stoic asceticism, insisting "I am not ... (neither would I be mistaken)" to be "of that mind". Allowing men the manifold pleasures God had given them, it was far from him to "lay any heavier burden upon any man, than the Lord himself."⁷ Indeed "[H]onest delight" and lawful recreation were "part of Christian liberty".⁸ Thus Bownde although

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5. Bownde, p 99.
NB One could argue that Bownde is simply saying that the Sabbatarian will never starve because of his Sabbath rest, though I am confident his meaning is broader, as I have represented it in the text.
6. ibid., p 272.
7. ibid., p 136-7.
8. Perkins, Works, I, p 539.

wary of fine secular music competing with psalm singing, was nevertheless scrupulous to insist:

I do not find fault with ...[it], ...
but do esteem of it, as I ought, even⁹
of the most exquisite that may be.

To confound those who charge puritans and Sabbatarians with condemning "gaiety in general",¹⁰ Bownde's 'general theory' of lawful earthly pleasures is outlined in a single sentence. It requires

that in all our lawful pleasures we should
look up to Him and so rejoice in
them, that we especially rejoice
in Him, and so from them be led to Him.¹¹

Earthly pleasures were not simply to be tolerated, they were an important part of Christian exaltation in the

9. Bownde, p 241.

He was less sympathetic to folk singing, which along with most elements of popular culture, he regarded as an idle, unfruitful invention for the passing of time which was also often attended with other "abominations" and profanities of the meaner sort.

10. Allen, op. cit., p 283.
cf. Weber, op. cit., p 105.

11. Bownde, p 238.

Lord and His works.¹² In fact both Greenham and Bownde gave substantial attention to the "spiritual use of the creatures [ie: Works of God]" on the Sabbath. Meditating on their "scope" and "beauty" the believer could gain strength,¹³ comfort and assurance.¹⁴ The evil made of God's earthly pleasures was of men's own doing, for where His pleasures brought the godly "nearer unto God", the "wicked" were, by them, drawn "away from God ... and ... into sin".¹⁵

12. pace Knappen, claiming the puritans' joy was "not ... based on the enjoyment of tangible things". This does not seem to be entirely correct in the light of the evidence which follows.
Rogers, Diary, p 9.

13. Greenham, p 308, 363, cf. 362, 364.

NB: "Creatures" used in this sense refers not only to God's animals but to other works. Thus bread, wine and water figure as creatures.

ibid. p 318. [paginated "310"].

14. Bownde, p 224, cf., 227, 229, 234.

15. ibid., p 238.

Thus the brethren's attitude to secular music, as with other "things indifferent", came back to the fruitfulness of its use; whether it "shall further us in godliness". Bownde stressed "that men might still have great commodity by it, if it were rightly used".¹⁶

Such invocations to lawful godly pleasures were part of those comforts and delights of godliness in this world to which the brethren seriously believed people might be attracted. Thus Bownde urged psalm singing on his readership as "not only good, but pleasant".¹⁷ And he sought to confound those in his day who, like some scholars of our day, saw puritan introspection and humiliation as fretful. "[T]rue humility" was "not to dismay us, but to comfort us with the hope of God's favour".¹⁸ Just as Rogers

16. Perkins, *Works*, I, p 540.
Bownde, 241. (my emphasis).

17. *ibid.*, p 244. (Bownde's emphasis).

18. Bownde, *Fasting*, p 96.

had himself weighed the "bitter cup" of "folly and licentiousness" as against the "comfort and happiness" of God's company, and chosen the latter,¹⁹ so he hoped

that the ungodly may see how [the godly]
are blessed in comparison, ... and what they ...
go void of which they might enjoy,
and therefore may seek how to become
not almost, but altogether Christians 20
with them.

In the following extract Greenham's exhortation to delight in the Sabbath is attended by a keen awareness of the attractiveness of religious and secular activities which competed with godly puritanism for people's affection.

19. Rogers, Diary, p 70.

20. Rogers, Treatises, sig A5 v.

[L]et us ... be no less careful to
bestow the first fruits of the Sabbath
day ... in the pure service of God,
than idolators in their idolatry,
young men in their vanities,
wordly men in their covetousness,
and heretics in their heresies use
to do.

21

Believing everyone to be "eaten up with the zeal of one
thing or other",²² he wanted to show people how they could,
by delighting in the Sabbath, displace their "zeal of
pleasure",²³ with godly zeal.

Thus, although Sabbatarianism involves an "oppressive
institution" for Allen,²⁴ as it might well have done for
Bownde's unregenerate contemporaries, for the godly it should
be, as God had commanded, their "whole delight". It must be
delightful because a lack of delight bespoke a choked
spirit. And delight might also be an enticing example to
the ungodly.

21. Greenham, pp 361-2, and cf above this extract on
p 361.

22. Greenham, (1612), p 46, aphorism 21.

23. ibid., p 653.

24. Allen, op.cit., p 270.

It was Catholic rituals and outward strictures that the puritans believed to be oppressive institutions. Accordingly Sabbatarian Sabbath exercises were not envisaged as meticulous and formal regimes. As Francis Merbury said introducing Rogers' Seven Treatises, "godly hunger is the best sauce for heavenly food" not the "conceited cookery" of Catholic pietistic rituals.²⁵

Because of that, the Lord knowing "how prone ... we are to weariness of well doing" had given the Christian a "great variety" of both private and public holy Sabbath exercises.²⁶ Using a plethora of exercises including "praying ..., meditating ... conferring ... singing ... teaching ...admonishing ... visiting others" and "viewing the creatures of God",²⁷ the Christian could stimulate

25. Rogers, Treatises, sig A4 v.

Note in this context Rogers refusal to set out a specific timetable for daily worship.

ibid., sig B4 r.

26. Rogers, Treatises, p 166.

27. Greenham, p 368-9.

his delight. That enabled "the whole time" to be "bestowed without tediousness and toil".²⁸

And so every Sunday the Sabbatarian, if he was not at church service, would be using those exercises either to prepare and "provoke" his "spiritual appetite" for church,²⁹ or, if he had attended the service, to more fully digest the lesson and apply it to himself.³⁰ The essence of the Sabbatarian Sabbath is captured in Greenham's arresting image of "a solemn banquet furnished with divers meats". Unless "the appetite be altogether gone the "weakest stomach

28. Rogers, loc cit.

29. Greenham, p 360.

30. Bownde, pp 202-3.

This emphasis on private and family exercises is often presented as a quasi-separatism, in which more private forms of peity become a "remedy for the shortcomings of the state Church".

Whether or not this can be observed later in the seventeenth century, the Sabbatarians were clear that such private exercises were directed towards making "the public exercises ... more profitable unto us".

Greenham was quite explicit on the matter.

[W]e deny not a blessing from the Lord on private prayer, reading and conference, but acknowledge a greater blessing to be due ... to ... exercises public ...

Hill, Society, p 501.

Greenham pp 362, 318 (sig. X7v).

cf Bownde, pp 195, 232.

not liking one dish, may refresh itself with another".³¹

I have tried to show in this and the previous chapter the many and powerful attractions of the uses of the Sabbath. Not surprisingly Bownde, wishing to impress those uses on his contemporaries, hoped "that this truth of GOD" might be brought forth "with the best credit".³² His attempt to do that is considered in the next chapter.

32. Greenham, p 369.

32. Bownde, sig A2 r.

CHAPTER 4

SABBATARIAN ARGUMENTATION

Greenham's and Bownde's attempts to impress the usefulness of the Sabbath on their contemporaries - like the puritans' attempts to impress 'puritanism' on their contemporaries - were marked by a keen awareness of their adversaries.

The Sabbath had "many and mighty enemies" represented by the enemies of true Protestantism.¹ The enemies of the Sabbath - "[t]hey that are deceived by false religion"² - were "either the Papists on ... one side" or various sects, "the families of love, with such like heretics on the other side".³ While the Papists - according to Greenham -

1. Bownde, p 29.

2. Greenham, p 300.

3. ibid.

taught the Christian Sabbath as an entirely human institution, the familists taught that it was a Jewish ceremony which should be abolished.⁴ The Sabbath's other enemy was 'lukewarmness'. Those many people "careless of religion" wanted a Sabbath but only for recreation, not religion.⁵

Also the 'friends' of the Sabbath could not agree.⁶

4. ibid., p 300-1.

Here and in what follows I merely seek to present the views of various parties as the Sabbatarians represented them. I am aware that the Sabbatarians' expressed views were sometimes misleading but I am concerned here with the way they saw and expressed things.

5. ibid. p 300.

6. "In the Children of God otherwise well instructed have ... arisen many scruples concerning this matter".

ibid., p 301.

Sprint ably summarised the "points of difference among the godly learned" which stood "in three distinct questions". Firstly whether the keeping of one day in seven was obligatory: secondly, if it was, whether Sunday had been instituted jure divino, as a law of God, or as a human and therefore mutable institution: thirdly whether another day might have been chosen and whether the church "hath yet authority or Christian liberty to abrogate or alter the Lord's day".⁷ Bownde said that no point of religion was "so in controversy among the learned ... as this of the Sabbath".⁸ "[I]ll opinions" were less hurtful ... amongst

7. Sprint, p 7.

8. Bownde, p 30.

NB. Though Greaves interprets such remarks as evidence that the "Anglican-Puritan controversy ... had already begun in earnest", this is unlikely. In 1597 Hooker supported most of Bownde's major theological arguments. Thus "God's immutable law doth exact forever" the "sanctification of one day in seven". That is to be done with "strict exaction".

Even without taking Hooker as the standard of "Anglicanism", he is most unlikely to have blithely supported the puritan side of an established partisan controversy.

By way of digression Hooker's evidence is also valuable because it indicates how far anti Sabbatarians like Thomas Rogers and Laudian Peter Heylyn were out on a limb in arguing that the Sabbath was a human institution, and why it is they who might more fittingly be regarded as innovators.

Greaves, op cit., p 28.

Hooker, op cit., Vol. II, [70:9], p 369.

the wicked and ignorant", but amongst "the learned and godly" they became "most dangerous",⁹ because they threatened the doctrinal concord of learned English Protestants and hence the English church itself.

The necessity for "unity" amongst learned Protestants "that we might join altogether against the common adversary" of all false religion, particularly popery, was expressed right across the religious political spectrum from Nicols and Perkins to King James at Hampton Court.¹⁰

9. Greenham, p 29.

Note here Hooker's reference to the "worlds's preservation" depending upon the "multitude of the wise". Though he was no friend of the brethren, the point is made as if it were common ground between them.

Hooker, op cit., [8.3], p 39.

10. King James, in Frederick Shriver, "Hampton Court Revisited: James I and the Puritans" Journal of Ecclesiastical History, 33(1982), p 48, at p 61.

Perkins, p 22.

And see the more general comments in Nichols, op cit., pp 95-97.

With concord at a premium the brethren sought to reprove only those errors of interpretation "which trouble[d] the church".¹¹ So Bownde was at pains to protest that he spoke not "rashly",¹² but because he believed his efforts might "redound to the glory of God, and the good of his church".¹³

Ironically enough the Sabbatarians believed or claimed to believe, that their contribution to the controversy might be definitive. In 1595 Bownde was in "good hope" that he had made "an end of my labours in that argument".¹⁴ The Sabbatarians entered the fray not out of any penchant for "frivolous wranglings",¹⁵ but because they wanted their

11. "all others" were to be "left alone".

Perkins, p 343.
cf Dering in Jensen, p 121.

12. Bownde, sig A4 r.

13. Bownde, Sabbathvm, sig A3 v.
cf Sprint, sig A 2 r.

14. ibid. sig A3 r.

15. Bownde, sig A4 r.

contemporaries to "make more conscience of observing the Lord's day"¹⁶ "but first of all, it [was] needful to prove" that the Sabbath had not been abrogated by the Gospel,

because without this persuasion,
all doctrine or exhortation tending
to the true manner of sanctifying it, 17
falleth to the ground...

The rest of this chapter deals with the Sabbatarian attempt to do that.

16. Bownde, p 28.

17. ibid., p 5.

-II

Though people often find what they are looking for in the Bible there are several reasons why the Sabbatarians would have found particularly compelling biblical authority for their Sabbath. Firstly, in interpreting the Bible to see what was temporary in the Fourth Commandment, and what was still binding, the usefulness of the Sabbath was itself an influential consideration.

When in the Old Testament a rule was given to the Jews "and hath a peculiar reason" applying to the Jew which "appertaine[d] nothing to the Christian", it was ceremonial. "[A]s it began with the Jews, ... it ceased with the Jews".¹ But "when the reason of the thing urged" was "not particular to the Jews, but also belongeth to the Christians; then the thing commanded" was "common to Jew and Gentile".² It was moral law applying to all mankind for all time. Obviously it was not a big step

1. Greenham, p 320.

2. ibid.

from perceiving the need for something "urged" in the Old Testament, to arguing that its "reason" was not "peculiar to the Jews". Thus Greenham typifies the Sabbatarian approach, arguing that, "as ... we need as necessary helps for religion as ever" the Jews did, "the same remaineth with us".³

In addition the brethren's faith in the sufficiency of the Bible, and their distrust of the opinions of "private men",⁴ had already led to a manner of interpreting the Bible, and particularly the Commandments, which led them on to find not simply divine injunctions to their own preferred position, but also a divine anticipation of, and response to, the sort of controversies about the Sabbath which they were witnessing.

The "diversity of opinions"⁵ on the Sabbath and other matters raised the problem of gaining secure faith and the "assurance going with it"⁶ which was part of Christian liberty and essential to salvation.⁷ With that yearning

3. ibid., p 311.

4. Perkins, Works, III, p 265.

5. ibid., III, p 324.

6. Rogers, Treatises, sig B[1] r.

7. ibid.

to find "sure grounds" of salvation Greeham believed

that the Lord ... hath not left
us to our own inventions in the means
of God's worship: and herein is
Christian dignity.

The "true glory of Christians ... consist[ed]" in having
not only the manner but also the time "of our religion
prescribed by God Himself".⁸

The Sabbatarians became captivated by the "very
particular manner" of God's Sabbath Commandment.⁹ "The
reason of it", they believed, was "so forcible and plain"
that it "cannot be avoided".¹⁰ Thus they stressed

8. Greenham, p 354.

9. Andrewes, p 324.
cf. Greenham, p 302, 352.
Bownde, p 107.

10. Andrewes, p 330.

the length of the Fourth Commandment not in a spirit of "irrational Bibliolatry" but because they saw, in the length of the commandment, a divine anticipation of, and attempt to prevent, Sabbath controversies. The Second and Fourth Commandments were the longest because God "plainly foresaw, how ... these two Commandments would... most be refused".¹¹ Such arguments were mainly put with heretics, particularly Papists, in mind. A similar approach governed the Sabbatarian response to the diversity of opinion upon the Sabbath within the Reformed Protestant camp. Bownde believed that the possibility of controversies amongst "them that do truly hold, that there ought to be a Sabbath",¹² had been "merciful[ly]" anticipated by God

11. ibid., p 305. Accordingly they were "amplified in words, and strengthened with more reasons "to captivate all mens inventions".

ibid.

12. Bownde, p 30.

who had "succoured the infirmity of man ... and decided the endless contention that might have been", by fixing the Sabbath to the "seventh day".¹³

It was partly this way of using the Bible "to end the strife"¹⁴ by settling controversies with biblical precedent, and partly the Sabbatarian desire to distance Christian liberty from civil liberty and libertinism,¹⁵ which gave rise to the most rigorous elements of Sabbatarianism. Greenham stressed that the Christian Sabbath "giveth no jot of liberty to worldly men" who sought private gain under pretence of "works of mercy".¹⁶

And when deciding when strict Sabbath rest could be broken, whether for instance one could break it during harvest or sowing time, the issue could be "shut up ... in a word". Not only was there the general commandment to rest

13. ibid., (Bownde's emphasis), and cf. p 33.

14. ibid., p 33.

15. Perkins, Works, I, p 538 distinguishes Christian from civil liberty.

16. Greenham, p 335.

but also God

hath in particulars met with all these
exceptions of times and business ...
that we might not measure ...
this rest, by the crooked rule
of our own imagination, ... but by the¹⁷
undeceivable line of His holy word.

So the Bible was scoured for Sabbath precedents, and most came from the Old Testament.

On the other points which divided the godly learned, the English Sabbatarians not surprisingly adopted biblical interpretations which stressed the immutability and importance of the Sabbath. Their positions on these points were not new but were gleaned from what Collinson calls "the orthodoxy of Heidelberg and Zurich, defined in the last quarter of the sixteenth century".¹⁸ Thus interpreting Genesis 2:2,3 as establishing the Sabbath as a creation ordinance, the Sabbatarians gave a fillip to their persuasion that the Sabbath was part of the moral, perpetual law. There were no figures of Christ "until sin came into the world" and no ceremonies until the Jews.¹⁹

17. Bownde, p 72. (Bownde's emphasis).
cf Andrewes, p 338-9.
Greenham, p 336 ff.

18. Collinson, "Beginnings", p 214.

19. Greenham, p 309.

Accordingly the Sabbath was not simply given to the "posterity of Abraham" - the Jews "but to the whole posterity of Adam" - mankind.²⁰

And noting the number of times the Old Testament God had punished Sabbath breakers as if they had broken the whole law, the Sabbatarians believed the Fourth Commandment to be "the sum of all in one syllogism".²¹ Bownde believed that "in the practice" of the Fourth Commandment "consisteth the practice of all the other".²² Having seen the godly Sabbath in Chapter Four we can appreciate Greenham's claim that the embracing of "this doctrine in conscience", would not leave a man to "lie long in the liking of sin".²³

20. ibid... Bownde put it, crisply

as it came in with the first man,
so it must not go out but with the
last man

Bownde, p 6.

21. Sprint, op cit., sig F4 r. [The page following the title page]. I am not suggesting that this particular view was a development of the Sabbatarians, though they probably expressed it with greater force and conviction than others.

22. Bownde, p 1.
cf Greenham, p 301.

23. Greenham, p 301-2.

There was disagreement amongst the learned about the extent to which the Fourth Commandment was moral. It had, since patristic times, been regarded as partly moral and partly ceremonial, and as such it stood, rather unhappily, as an anomaly amongst all the other Commandments which were wholly moral. Calvin had regarded almost all of the Fourth Commandment as moral,¹ and, though he considered the requirement of the seventh day to be ceremonial, his treatment of the Commandment as partly moral, and partly ceremonial, appears to stem in part from deference to patristic authority.²

With the Sabbath tied to the seventh day an exclusively moral Decalogue became theologically tenable.

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1. Even the rest for beasts.
Calvin, op cit., sig. fol 45 r.
 2. John Calvin, Institutes of the Christian Religion,
Translated by F L Battles, 2 Vols., London, 1961, Book
II, Chapter 8, S.28, Vol. I, pp 394-5.

Having shrugged off the weight of authority, as some had already done in Europe,³ the Sabbatarians could take a wholly moral Fourth Commandment and an exclusively moral Decalogue to the world as one of God's special revelations of his truth "unto this age of ours".⁴

This is a worthy subject with which to conclude the body of the essay because in understanding their claim and how they came to make it we get a neat illustration of just how 'practical' their theological arguments were, and how powerfully those arguments could influence contemporary minds.

Andrewes argued that the Fourth Commandment was moral, because, along with the other nine Commandments, it came from God "immediately" not, like parts of the ceremonial law, via "the ministry of Moses".⁵

3. Collinson, "Beginnings", p 213-4.

4. Sprint, p 9, and cf Greenham cited in Knappen, Tudor Puritanism, p 346.

5. Andrewes, p 330. (Andrewes' emphasis).
cf Greenham, (1612), p 810,
Greenham, pp 315-16.
Bownde, Sabbathvm, p 39.

The obvious intellectual appeal of removing from the Fourth Commandment its status as an anomaly, figures as theological argumentation.

It will fall against order for a
ceremonial precept to stand in the 6
midst among moral commandments.

6. Andrewes loc cit., (Andrewes' emphasis).
cf Greenham, p 315.
Bownde, Sabbathvm, p 40.

But the most compelling reason for the exclusively moral Decalogue was its practical value in more forcefully asserting that Decalogue against the enemies of true religion. Here the Sabbatarians' argumentation deviates strikingly from its usual nominally theological tenor. The argument refers, not to canons of Biblical interpretation, but strictly to the practicalities of the struggle between true religion and its adversaries.

With Papists oppugning the Second Commandment as ceremonial,⁷ and "carnal gospellers" and "atheists" threatening to oppugn other commandments,⁸ the exclusively moral Decalogue was "the best way for upholding the duties Eternal ... to keep them without blemish".⁹ And the moral Decalogue was a standard which Christians could use, as the Jews had, to keep them on the narrow path, for, as Greenham argued, "we need a perfect rule as well as the Jews, to preserve us from idolatry and heresy".¹⁰

We have seen on several occasions attention being given to the Fourth Commandment in company with the Second.¹¹ With those Commandments considered together as

7. Andrewes, p 331.
cf Sprint, op cit., p 10.

8. Sprint, op.cit., p 10.

9. Andrewes, p 331.
cf Greenham, p 316.
Sprint, op.cit., p 10.

10. Greenham, p 316.

11. Andrewes, p 330 has already been cited. Other examples include Greenham pp 305, 306, 316, 353.
Bownde, pp 8-9.

the two most oppugned by man's reason¹² there was an undertone suggesting that they were something of a key to true religion. The Second Commandment was already a shibboleth against popery and 'popish' corruptions of true religion and by association the Fourth Commandment was acquiring a similar status. Greenham said that where "these two Commandments are not rightly understood, there the true religion goeth to wrack".¹³ He was suggesting that the Sabbath was one of those bastions of true Protestantism against all those false doctrines to which men's ears were "ticking".¹⁴ Those doctrines were wrought not from God's word but from man's flesh, and so, instead of lifting man's eyes to heaven, by preying on his weaknesses, they kept him in confusion and darkness. If they were to tighten their grip on England they would bring more sin, rebellion and disobedience, and worse judgments from God. It becomes more understandable that about 50 years after the first

12. Greenham, p 305.

13. ibid. p 306.

14. ibid. p 29.

Sabbatarian treatises were written, many "moderate men" regarded Charles I's assault on the godly Sabbath¹⁵ as a "principal cause of the civil war".¹⁶

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15. In 1633 Charles I republished his father's notorious "Book of Sports" permitting various "lawful recreations" and "honest exercises" which included dancing, leaping, vaulting, archery, inter alia, but not recreations which were already frowned upon and/or prohibited, like bull and bearbaitings, and interludes.

Whitaker, op cit., p 92, 94.

16. Hill, Society, p 201.

CHAPTER 5

CONCLUSION

Many historians studying the Sabbatarrians have concentrated upon what was new about their position, and the theological differences which emerged between them and their opponents. The resulting emphasis has been on the argumentation of the Sabbatarrians and their opponents rather than on their respective motivations.

In order not to interpret the phenomenon of Sabbatarrianism simply in terms of the theological arguments involved, Christopher Hill proposed a dichotomy between 'intellectual' and 'social' influences, which he expressed in the contrast between "mere irrational Bibliolatry", and "the pressures and demands of society".¹ It was important for Hill to explore the 'social' causes of Sabbatarrianism, because, as he suggests elsewhere, "any body of thought" which 'takes on', does so "because it meets the needs of significant groups in the society".² Wallace is similarly keen to discern

1. Hill, Society, p 146.

2. Christopher Hill, Intellectual Origins of the English Revolution, Oxford, 1965, p 3.

influences shaping puritan thought which were "other than intellectual".³ But surely implicit in such statements is a rather impoverished view of what intellectual activity is. It seems to envisage thinking as directed to the production of closed formal games, rather than to the solving of problems.⁴

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3. Wallace, op cit., p 46.
cf William K B Stoevers, A Faire and Easie Way to Heaven: Covenant Theology and Antinomianism in Early Massechussets, Middleton, Conneticut, 1978, p 16 ff, where the same dichotomy between "concrete" and "ideological" influences is posed, though I would suggest in a more thoughtful way.
4. cf. Dunn, op. cit., p 88, extracted above, p 10, in note 12.

Sabbatarianism, as we have seen, was directed to solving quite specific problems of this world. Plagues, and the profanity and disorder involved in much popular culture were such problems. But in presenting a body of thought as a solution to problems we should not underestimate the way in which intellectual preconceptions themselves moulded perceptions of what the problems were in the first place. Perceiving the social problems around them as related symptoms of a disease in English society - its rejection of God's ways - the Sabbatarians were, to use the words of their near contemporary, "T.W", seeking not to "bodge" or patch up the disease, but cure it "in the cause".⁵ Like other puritans they sought to improve the temporal health of England by improving its spiritual health. With

5. Collier, op cit., p 230.

'political puritanism' for the time being doomed to futility Bownde directed his arguments to those in authority urging them to fulfil their duty to cut down the sin of the ungodly. And where the magistrate remained unmoved Bownde's exhortations turned to the godly to do what they could do for the church and the commonwealth by renewing their commitment to godliness and God's Sabbath.

In this essay we examined Sabbatarian argumentation only after appreciating the attractions of the Sabbath. In that light we could see how, what might otherwise seem abstruse "Bibliolatry", could be an attractive and even compelling argument. As the Sabbatarians said themselves,

Sabbatarianism had its roots in practicality rather than abstractions of theology.

As a social policy Sabbatarianism would

If it were well received and believed, ...
make very effectually to the great
increase of godliness, and to the cutting 6
down of much sin and impiety.

When applied by the godly to their own lives it could be

a principal means whereby the seed of
religion is sown in our hearts, and the 7
holy fire ... is kept in among us.

Like Nicols, the Sabbatarians believed that if godliness might flourish in England

how happy, how quiet how free from
all danger the estate would be. 8

6. Sprint, op cit., sig A2 v.

7. George Widley, The Doctrine of the Sabbath, London, 1604, sig A2 v.

8. Nicols, op. cit., p 174.

For Greenham the "necessary use" of the doctrine of the Sabbath was demonstrated, not by abstruse theological argument but by

the lamentable inconveniences which accompany the want of the pure understanding thereof: [and] the manifold commodities, which ensue, [from] the right embracing of⁹ the same.

That was why Bownde insisted that his argument was

not only that the Sabbath ought to be continued, but that we take it as a principal mercy, that the Lord hath¹⁰ reserved it unto [us].

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9. Greenham, p 300. This is virtually the first thing Greenham says in support of the 'doctrine of the Sabbath'.
 10. Bownde, p 19. The last word of the quotation, which I have guessed to be "us", is illegible in my copy.

Appendix

This appendix, being essentially a transplanted footnote, is limited in scope. It includes information which, in addition to the brethren's godly puritan outlook, provides further evidence of their sympathy with, and/or even participation in, the presbyterian 'classis' movement.

Perkins

Perkins was on the fringes of the classis movement, attending meetings at St Johns in 1589.¹ Sisson has argued that Perkins attended classes "in a simple spirit of inquiry", though this is unsupported by firm evidence and is founded upon her erroneous view that while Perkins saw himself as an apologist for the Church of England, the presbyterians did not see themselves in such a light.²

1. Rosemary A Sisson, "William Perkins, Apologist for the Elizabethan Church of England", Modern Language Review, 47 (1952), p 495, at p 500.

2. ibid.

While Hill's claim, that Perkins was a "member" of the classis movement,³ may risk going further than the evidence permitted, by far the most plausible interpretation is that Perkins, and men like his friend and mentor Laurence Chaderton, attended because they were at least, generally sympathetic to the views and aims of others in attendance.

Rogers

In his diary Rogers refers to the presbyterian ministers imprisoned and harassed by Whitgift's offensive of 1589 as his "betters". He also reveals throughout that he took part in the classes. Rogers was also suspended from preaching in 1589.⁴

3. Hill, Society, p 502.

4. Rogers, Diary, p 91.

Andrewes

Andrewes, despite his later career, seems to have attended the same sort of meetings as Perkins. Three of his companions were 'moderate puritans' one of them - Laurence Chaderton - attending the very same meeting at Cambridge, for which Perkins had to answer to Star Chamber.⁵

Greenham

Greenham sympathised with Cartwright in his troubles at Cambridge, was involved in the classis movement, and was briefly suspended for non-conformity in the '70s.⁶ Also, at one point, Greenham's language suggests that he believes "new church government" to be a "good thing to come".⁷

Bownde

We know less about Bownde though he shared many of the views of the presbyterians. He was emphatic in his desire to "clean ... put out" and "destroy all remnants" of Catholicism in England.⁸ Like the presbyterians he was

5. Knappen, "Early Puritanism", op cit., p 97, 98.
Sisson, loc. cit..

6. Knappen, Tudon Puritanism, p 382.

7. Greenham, (1612), p 48, aphorism 56.

8. Bownde, p 277.

hostile to holy days. And, though it was far from a major theme of his Sabbatarianism,⁹ like Greenham, he was sympathetic to Cartwright's claim that the church had no authority to ordain holy days.¹⁰

It is also worth noting that the enemies of Sabbatarianism associated it with presbyterianism, though, given their polemic purposes, this may not be much more than a general statement execrating the general political-religious orientation of their opponents.¹¹

9. pace, Hill, Society, p 153 ff.

10. Bownde, p 31;
Greenham, 810;
T.C.[Thomas Cartwright], A Reply made of M Doctor Whitegift, 1574, p 152.

11. Thomas Rogers, op. cit., p 17. Heylyn, op. cit., p 250.

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